

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Book Two

ONLY IF IT WAITS

by

MRETYUN JAI B

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Written by
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**"Every decision creates a future.
Some decisions create two."**

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Can Love Survive?

Book Two – Only If It Waits

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First Edition

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Dedication

For those who chose patience...

For those who stayed.

For those who listened.

For those who believed that one honest
conversation can change an entire future.

This story is for everyone who learned that
love isn't only about finding the right
person...

Sometimes...

it's about becoming the right person

Before You Begin...

This is not another love story.

It is another possibility.

The same people.

The same memories.

The same beginning.

Only...

one different choice.

**Sometimes life changes because of what
we say.**

Sometimes...

**it changes because we waited long
enough to understand.**

If Book I was about regret...

Book II is about patience.

Welcome back.

Author's Note

"Every story begins with a choice.

Book I asked what happens when emotions speak
before understanding.

Book II asked what happens when patience speaks
before emotions.

Neither ending is more real than the other.

Both are possible.

Because life rarely gives us only one future.

Thank you for walking beside Mithran one last time.

— MRETYUN JAI B

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Part VI - Choice That Changed Everything.. 13

Chapter Twenty-Six	13
Chapter Twenty-Seven.....	36
Chapter Twenty-Eight.....	57
Chapter Twenty-Nine.....	76
Chapter Thirty	94
Chapter Thirty-One	122
Chapter Thirty-Two.....	143
Chapter Thirty-Three	161
Chapter Thirty-Four	180
Chapter Thirty-Five	209

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BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

PROLOGUE

There is something beautiful...
and terrifying...
about a single decision.
Most people never notice it.
One reply.
One conversation.
One moment of patience.
Or one moment of pride.
Can quietly rewrite decades.
This story begins exactly where another one could
have begun.
The people are the same.
The memories are the same.
The hearts are the same.
Only...
one decision is different.
And sometimes...
that's enough.
— **M.**

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...

Sometimes...

Yes.

Only if it waits

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Part VI - Choice That Changed Everything

Chapter Twenty-Six

The Message I Never Sent

The bus slowly left Bangalore.
The city lights disappeared behind me.
I kept looking outside...
but I couldn't see anything.
My eyes were filled with tears.
I leaned against the window.
Closed my eyes.
Every moment of the past few days...
kept replaying inside my head.
June 17.
The card game.
Her smile.
The silence.
The goodbye.
Everything.
Again...
and again.
I took out my phone.
Opened WhatsApp.
Our chat was still open.
The cursor blinked.
Waiting.
Just like me.

Without thinking...
my fingers started typing.
"Why didn't you talk to me properly?"
"Why did you ignore me?"
"Why did you leave my messages on seen?"
"Do I really mean this little to you?"
I read every word.
Twice.
Then a third time.
My thumb slowly moved towards the send button.
It stopped.
For a few seconds...
I simply stared at the screen.
A question suddenly appeared inside my mind.
"What happens after I send this?"
Would I feel better?
Or would I lose the person I cared about the most?
I remembered something she once told me.
"I don't want to lose anyone important again."
I closed my eyes.
Took a deep breath.
Then...
I selected every single word.
Delete.
The screen became empty.
Just like before.
For the first time that night...
my heart felt slightly lighter.
I started typing again.
Much slower this time.
"Sorry..."
"I think I behaved differently these last few days."

"Maybe I overthought everything."

"If I made you uncomfortable..."

"I'm really sorry."

I looked at the message.

It wasn't perfect.

But...

it was honest.

My thumb pressed...

Send.

I locked my phone.

Placed it beside me.

Looked outside again.

The highway stretched endlessly into the darkness.

For the first time in six days...

I wasn't expecting an answer.

I was simply hoping...

our friendship would survive.

Almost five minutes passed.

My phone vibrated.

Aashika Calling...

For a moment...

I just looked at her name.

Then...

a small smile appeared on my face.

I answered.

"...Hello?"

There was silence.

Only for a second.

Then...

she softly said,

"I'm sorry."

I looked at the screen for a few seconds before answering.

Her name was still glowing on my phone.

Aashika Calling...

A few minutes ago, I had almost destroyed years of friendship with one message.

Now...

the same person was calling me.

I slowly swiped the answer button.

"Hello..."

Neither of us spoke.

The silence between us wasn't uncomfortable.

It was simply filled with words neither of us knew how to begin with.

The sound of the bus engine quietly echoed in the background as the highway lights passed one after another outside my window.

Then...

I heard her breathing.

Very softly.

"I'm sorry..."

Those were the first words she spoke.

Not "Hello."

Not "How are you?"

Just...

"I'm sorry."

I closed my eyes for a moment.

Hearing those two words somehow made the heaviness inside me disappear little by little.

"You don't have to apologize," I replied softly.

"I do."

"No..."

"I really do."

There was another short silence.

Then she continued.

"I thought you were angry with me."

"I didn't know how to speak to you after that."

"Every time I came near you..."

"I felt like you didn't even want to look at me."

Her voice sounded completely different from what I had imagined during the past few days.

All this time...

I thought she didn't care.

But now...

I realized she had been overthinking too.

I smiled to myself.

"I wasn't angry."

"I was just..."

I stopped speaking.

She immediately completed my sentence.

"Overthinking?"

I laughed.

A small laugh escaped before I could stop it.

"Yeah..."

"I was."

She laughed too.

"There he is."

"What?"

"The overthinking Mithran I know."

"I was wondering where he disappeared."

I shook my head while smiling.

"I hate you."

"No, you don't."

"...Maybe."

She laughed again.
Hearing her laugh after six days felt strangely
comforting.
It reminded me of every late-night call we had shared
during the lockdown.
Every random conversation.
Every stupid joke.
Every argument that never lasted more than a few
minutes.
How did we allow six days of silence to become this
heavy?
"I really thought you hated me," she admitted.
"I even told my sister."
"What did she say?"
"She asked me..."
'Why don't you just go and talk to him?'
"And?"
"I couldn't."
"Why?"
"I don't know."
"I kept waiting for you."
I looked outside the window.
Streetlights rushed past like tiny stars.
"I was waiting for you too."
Both of us became quiet again.
Then she suddenly said,
"You know something?"
"What?"
"We're both idiots."
That made me laugh louder than before.
"That's actually true."
"We wasted six days."

"Six whole days."

"Because neither of us wanted to say one sentence."

I nodded even though she couldn't see me.

"I'm sorry," I said again.

"I shouldn't have behaved like that."

"No."

"We both made mistakes."

"You expected me to understand your silence."

"And I expected you to understand mine."

Neither of us was right.

Neither of us was wrong.

We were simply two people waiting for the other to take the first step.

"I've learnt one thing," she said.

"What?"

"If something like this ever happens again..."

"I'm not waiting."

"I'll call you immediately."

I smiled.

"You don't even have to call."

"A message is enough."

"No."

She interrupted.

"Messages create misunderstandings."

"I'll call."

There was confidence in her voice.

For some reason...

that promise made me feel safe.

I leaned my head against the bus window.

The cold glass touched my forehead.

The road ahead disappeared into darkness.

Yet...

my heart felt lighter than it had in days.

"So..."

she suddenly asked.

"Did you eat dinner?"

I smiled.

"There she is."

"What?"

we spoke exactly the way we always used to.

She told me about what happened after I left.

Her father had reached home safely.

Her mother asked why both of us were unusually quiet.

Her sister noticed something was wrong but didn't ask.

I listened to everything patiently.

Then she asked about my journey.

Whether I had eaten.

Whether the bus was comfortable.

Whether I had slept.

I honestly answered every question.

"No."

"I haven't slept at all."

"I knew it."

"How?"

"I know you."

That sentence stayed in my heart.

Not because it was romantic.

Because it was true.

She knew me better than most people around me.

After talking for nearly an hour...

she suddenly became quiet.

"Mithran..."

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"Hmm?"

"Promise me something."

"What?"

"No more silent treatment."

"No more assuming."

"If you're hurt..."

"Tell me."

"If I'm hurt..."

"I'll tell you."

I smiled.

"Promise."

"No..."

she corrected immediately.

"Say it properly."

I laughed.

"Fine."

"I promise."

"Good."

"And you?"

"I promise too."

Another few minutes passed.

Neither of us wanted to end the call.

Not because we had something important to discuss.

Because both of us were afraid of returning to the
silence that had hurt us so much.

Finally...

she sighed.

"You should sleep."

"I know."

"You've got a long journey."

"And you've got college."

"Mmm."

There was another pause.

Then she softly said,

"Thank you..."

I frowned.

"For what?"

"For calling me back."

I smiled.

"I didn't call you."

"You called me."

"I know."

"But you answered."

Without saying another word...

I looked outside the window.

For the first time since leaving Bangalore...

I wasn't thinking about June 17.

I wasn't thinking about the card game.

I wasn't thinking about the silence.

I was simply grateful...

that one deleted message had saved a friendship that
meant the world to both of us.

The call should have ended there.

We had already apologized.

The misunderstanding had disappeared.

But somehow...

neither of us wanted to disconnect.

It felt as though both of us were trying to make up
for the six days we had wasted in silence.

"So..."

she suddenly asked.

"What are you doing now?"

I looked around the bus.

Most of the passengers were already asleep.

The lights inside had been dimmed.
Only a few mobile screens glowed in the darkness.
"I'm sitting near the window."
I guessed that."
"How?"
"You always choose the window seat."
I smiled.
"You remember?"
She laughed softly.
"Of course I remember."
"You never sleep during bus journeys."
"You keep looking outside as if you're searching for something."
"I still don't know what."
I looked outside again.
Dark roads.
Occasional street lights.
The reflection of my own face on the window.
"I don't know either."
I replied honestly.
"Maybe I'm just watching life pass by."
She remained silent for a few seconds.
Then she changed the topic.
"Did you eat anything?"
"Yeah."
"What?"
I scratched my head.
"I don't even remember."
She laughed.
"You definitely skipped dinner."
"No..."
"I ate."

"What?"

I stayed quiet.

She immediately understood.

"Mithran..."

"I know you."

"You didn't eat properly."

"I wasn't hungry."

"That's not an excuse."

"I'll eat after reaching home."

"No."

"You'll forget."

I laughed.

"I won't."

"You always say that."

Then she suddenly became serious.

"Promise me you'll eat after reaching home."

"I promise."

And sleep."

"I'll try."

"No..."

she corrected.

"You'll sleep."

"I'll try."

"Mithran..."

"Okay..."

"I'll sleep."

"Good."

She was exactly the same.

Always reminding me to eat.

Always reminding me to sleep.

Always worrying about things I ignored.

For a moment...

I realized how close I had come to losing all of this.

She suddenly asked,

"By the way..."

"Hmm?"

"What happened to your placement training?"

"It went well."

"So..."

"When are you joining?"

I told her everything.

About the company.

About the joining process.

About the excitement.

About the fear of starting my first job.

She listened without interrupting.

Just like she always did.

"You'll do well."

she said confidently.

"I don't know."

"You will."

"What makes you so sure?"

"Because..."

"I've seen how hard you work."

Those words meant more than she realized.

There are compliments that people give politely.

And then there are compliments from someone who has watched your journey.

This was the second kind.

"What about you?"

I asked.

"How's college?"

She let out a long sigh.

"Assignments."

"Seminars."

"Internal exams."

"Life is terrible."

I laughed.

"Sounds normal."

"Don't laugh."

"You escaped."

"I still have to suffer."

"I'll pray for you."

"Very funny."

"It wasn't supposed to be."

She laughed again.

The conversation slowly became lighter.

The heaviness from the past week quietly disappeared.

We spoke about random things.

Her sister.

Her brother-in-law.

Funny incidents at home.

The street shopping we had done a few days earlier.

The driving lesson.

The ice cream at midnight.

The UNO games.

Even the "YouKnow" cards.

She suddenly asked,

"By the way..."

"When are you making Version 2 of your card game?"

I smiled.

"So you liked it?"

"I never said that."

"You played it."

"That doesn't mean I liked it."

"Then why were you smiling while playing?"

"I wasn't smiling."

"You were."

"I wasn't."

"You definitely were."

She laughed.

"Fine..."

"It was actually fun."

"There."

"I made you admit it."

"Don't get overconfident."

For a few moments...

we simply laughed.

Neither of us realized how important those small conversations would become years later.

After a while...

the bus stopped near a highway restaurant.

The conductor switched on the lights.

"Ten minutes."

he announced.

Passengers slowly got down.

Stretching.

Yawning.

Walking towards the food stalls.

"You got down?"

she asked.

"Yeah."

"What are you eating?"

"I don't know."

"Go eat something."

"I will."

"And don't tell me you're buying tea."

I laughed immediately.

"You know I don't drink tea."

"Tea, coffee, milk..."

she continued.

"You don't drink anything."

"I do."

"What?"

"Water."

She burst into laughter.

"I've never seen someone survive only on water."

"I also drink fruit juice."

"Oh wow."

"So healthy."

"Very."

"Buy a juice then."

"At two in the morning?"

"They'll have one."

"I'll check."

I walked towards the small shop.

There wasn't much.

Biscuits.

Chips.

Cold drinks.

A refrigerator filled with fruit juice.

I picked up a mango juice.

Just as I was about to pay...

my phone vibrated again.

"Did you buy it?"

she asked immediately.

I looked at the juice packet and smiled.

"Yes."

"What flavour?"

"Mango."

"Good."

"I thought you'd buy nothing."

"I promised you."

"So I had to."

I took a sip while standing under the night sky.

The cool wind brushed past my face.

For the first time in days...

everything felt peaceful again.

The conductor blew his whistle.

Passengers slowly returned.

"I have to go."

I said.

"I know."

"Message me after reaching."

"I will."

"And..."

she paused.

"...travel safely."

"You too."

"Sleep."

"I'll try."

"Mithran..."

"Okay..."

"I'll sleep."

She laughed one last time.

"Good night."

"Good night."

The call ended.

I looked at the dark screen for a few seconds before
keeping my phone inside my pocket.

The bus slowly started moving again.

This time...
I didn't look outside searching for answers.
I simply leaned back in my seat.
Closed my eyes.
And within a few minutes...
after six sleepless nights...
I finally fell asleep.
The next morning...
I woke up to the sound of my mother's voice.
"Mithran..."
"We've reached."
For a moment...
I forgot where I was.
Then I looked through the bus window.
Trichy.
Home.
I smiled.
The journey had ended.
But thankfully...
our misunderstanding had too.
After reaching home, I took a quick shower and
finally slept.
When I woke up again, it was already afternoon.
As usual...
the first thing I did wasn't checking the time.
It was checking my phone.
There was a message.
Aashika.
"Reached?"
The message had come almost three hours earlier.
I smiled without realizing it.
She had remembered.

I quickly replied.

"Yes... I reached safely."

Barely thirty seconds later...

my phone vibrated.

"Good."

"Now eat properly."

"And don't tell me you're sleeping again."

I laughed.

"Too late."

"I already slept."

Three laughing emojis appeared on my screen.

Then she replied,

"Good."

"At least you listened to me once."

That simple conversation...

felt more precious than any long emotional speech.

Sometimes...

happiness quietly returns through ordinary messages.

The next few days slowly returned to normal.

Our daily routine somehow found its old rhythm again.

She would call me after college.

I would call her after placement training.

Sometimes we spoke for ten minutes.

Sometimes for two hours.

Sometimes...

there wasn't even anything important to discuss.

Yet we still stayed on the call.

One evening...

she called while walking back from college.

"I have exciting news."

"What happened?"

"I passed my internal assessment."

"Congratulations."

"I told you I'd pass."

"I never said you wouldn't."

"You didn't have confidence."

"I had."

"You didn't."

"I did."

"You didn't."

I laughed.

"Fine."

"You won."

"I know."

Another day...

I called her after returning from college.

"What are you doing?"

"Trying to study."

"Trying?"

"Yes."

"The book is open."

"My mind is somewhere else."

I smiled.

"Where?"

"Thinking about dinner."

I burst into laughter.

"You haven't changed."

"I don't want to."

Slowly...

those little conversations filled the gap the silence had created.

Without either of us noticing...

the awkwardness completely disappeared.

Days became weeks.
Weeks slowly became months.
Neither of us ever mentioned June 17 again.
Not because we had forgotten.
But because we had already forgiven each other.
Some memories don't need explanations.
They simply teach us something and quietly become
part of us.
One Sunday evening...
I was cleaning my room when my phone rang.
It was Aashika.
"Busy?"
"A little."
"What are you doing?"
"Cleaning."
She immediately laughed.
"You?"
"I know."
"Even I'm surprised."
She continued laughing.
"I wish I could see that."
"I'll send you a picture."
"You better."
I looked around my room.
Books were scattered everywhere.
Clothes lay on the chair.
The table looked like a battlefield.
I quickly cleaned one corner.
Placed my phone there.
Took a picture.
And sent it.
Within seconds...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

she replied.

"Only one side?"

"Show the rest of the room."

I laughed loudly.

"You caught me."

"I know you too well."

That sentence stayed with me.

"I know you too well."

There was comfort in those words.

Not because someone understood me perfectly.

But because after everything that had happened...

she still did.

That night...

before sleeping...

I opened our chat once again.

I slowly scrolled upward.

Past the jokes.

Past the photos.

Past the random conversations.

Until I reached the message I had sent from the bus.

The apology.

I read it quietly.

Then smiled.

If I had chosen the other message...

none of these conversations would have existed
today.

One deleted message...

had protected years of memories.

From that day onwards...

I made a small promise to myself.

Whenever my heart wanted to speak in anger...

I would wait.

Whenever my mind created stories that never happened...
I would ask first.
And whenever silence started growing between us...
I would break it.
Because I had finally understood something.
Friendships don't end because people stop caring.
They end because people stop communicating.
I never wanted that to happen again.
That night...before going to sleep...
my phone vibrated. A single message.
From Aashika.
"Good night, idiot."
I smiled.
Then typed back.
"Good night."
A few seconds later...
another message appeared.
"Thank you... for staying."
I looked at those words for a long time.
Then... without thinking twice...
I replied.
"After all this time?"
She replied with a confused emoji.
I smiled to myself.
And typed only one word.
"Always."
I locked my phone. Turned off the light. And for the first time...
I felt that maybe...
some friendships were worth fighting for.
Not with each other. But for each other.

Chapter Twenty-Seven

Growing Together

Almost a year had passed since that night on the bus.
Without realizing it...
life had quietly moved forward.
College had ended.
Placements had become jobs.
Assignments had become responsibilities.
And the conversations that once revolved around
exams and attendance...
slowly turned into discussions about interviews,
salaries, and the future.
Somehow...
we had entered adulthood together.
One evening...
while talking on the phone, I casually asked,
"What are you planning after college?"
"I don't know."
"What do you mean you don't know?"
She laughed.
"I'm waiting for my final results first."
"And after that?"
"I'll probably start looking for a job."
"You'll definitely get one."
"So much confidence?"
"I've seen how hard you work."
She became quiet.
After a few seconds...
she softly replied,

"Thank you."

A few months later...

both of us had started working.

Not in the same company.

But in the same city.

Bangalore.

The city that had always connected our stories.

Since my office was also in Bangalore...

I moved there for work.

Just like before...

I stayed at Aashika's house.

Only this time...

everything felt different.

Not because our friendship had changed.

Because our lives had.

The next morning was my first day at work.

I woke up earlier than everyone else.

Ironed my shirt.

Checked my documents three times.

Then checked them once more.

My nervousness was obvious.

As I was adjusting my tie in front of the mirror...

someone knocked gently on the door.

It was Aashika.

She looked at me for a second.

Then smiled.

"So..."

"Mr. Employee."

"You finally grew up."

I laughed.

"I don't feel like it."

"You will."

She noticed my expression.

"Nervous?"

"A little."

"A little?"

"Okay..."

"A lot."

She laughed.

"Relax."

"It's just the first day."

"You'll survive."

"I hope so."

A few minutes later...

everyone gathered for breakfast.

Her father looked at both of us.

"So...", "First day?"

We both nodded.

He smiled proudly.

"All the best."

Her mother placed breakfast on the table.

"Eat properly."

"Don't skip meals."

She looked at me while saying the last sentence.

Everyone laughed.

Aashika immediately smiled.

"See...", "I wasn't the only one reminding you."

After breakfast...

we picked up our bags.

Stepped outside.

The morning air was cool.

The streets were already filling with people rushing towards work.

For the first time...

both of us were part of that crowd.
"Ready?"
she asked.
"As ready as I'll ever be."
We started walking towards the bus stop together.
Neither of us spoke for a while.
Not because there was nothing to say.
Because both of us were quietly taking in the
moment.
School had ended.
College had ended.
And now...
another chapter of life had begun.
The bus arrived.
As usual...
it was crowded.
We somehow managed to get inside.
Standing near each other...
trying not to lose balance whenever the driver
suddenly applied the brakes.
"This feels familiar."
I said.
"What?"
"Travelling together."
She smiled.
"Except this time..."
"We're going to work."
Instead of college.
Instead of family functions.
Instead of holidays.
Life had changed.
But somehow...

the person standing beside me hadn't.
Half an hour later...
the bus stopped near my office.
"This is my stop."
I said.
She nodded.
"My office is three stops ahead."
I stepped down.
The bus doors slowly closed.
She waved.
"All the best."
"You too."
The bus slowly moved away.
I stood there for a few seconds.
Watching it disappear into the morning traffic.
Then I turned around.
Looked at the glass building in front of me.
Took a deep breath.
And walked inside.
My first day at work wasn't as frightening as I had
imagined.
New faces.
New desks.
New responsibilities.
Everyone looked just as nervous as I was.
That somehow made me feel better.
Throughout the day...
I kept checking my phone whenever I got a break.
Not because I was expecting something important.
Simply because...
for years...
telling Aashika how my day went had become a habit.

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Around lunchtime...
my phone vibrated.
Aashika
"Survived?"
I smiled immediately.
I replied.
"Barely."
Within seconds...
another message arrived.
"Same here."
"I already want to go home."
I laughed quietly.
My colleague looked at me.
"What happened?"
"Nothing."
I locked my phone.
Still smiling.
That evening...
I reached home first.
After changing my clothes...
I sat in the living room.
About twenty minutes later...
the front door opened.
Aashika walked in.
She looked exhausted.
The moment she saw me...
she dropped her bag onto the sofa dramatically.
"I'm never going to work again."
I burst into laughter.
"One day."
"You worked for one day."
"That's enough."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

She sat down.
Her mother brought both of us fresh orange juice.
Aashika looked at me.
"You got tea?"
I immediately shook my head.
"You know I don't drink tea."
Her mother smiled.
"So I made juice for both of you."
I picked up the glass.
"Thank you, Aunty."
The cold orange juice somehow tasted better after an
entire day at work.
That evening...
we spent almost two hours talking about our first day.
Not because anything extraordinary had happened.
But because ordinary things become interesting...
when you share them with the right person.
Outside...
the sun slowly disappeared behind the buildings.
Inside the house...
two tired employees laughed over the smallest
moments of their first working day.
Neither of us knew it then...
but these ordinary evenings would later become some
of the happiest memories we would ever carry.
The first week passed much faster than either of us
expected.
Every morning...
our routine became almost identical.
Both of us would wake up before seven.
Her mother would already be busy in the kitchen,
preparing breakfast while reminding us not to be late.

Her father would be reading the newspaper in the living room, occasionally looking over the top of it just to ask,

"So... who has the earlier meeting today?"

Some mornings it was me.

Some mornings it was Aashika.

It somehow became a small competition between us.

"You're late."

I said one morning while looking at my watch.

She looked at me without any guilt.

"I'm exactly on time."

"No."

"You're two minutes late."

She folded her hands.

"You've been working for only two weeks."

"When did you become so punctual?"

I smiled.

"I've always been punctual."

She laughed immediately.

"You?"

"The same person who almost missed a train because he was buying chips?"

I looked away.

"That happened only once."

"It happened twice."

"It happened once."

She looked towards her mother.

"Aunty..."

"Tell him."

Her mother laughed.

"It happened twice."

I sighed dramatically.

"No one supports me in this house."
Everyone started laughing.
Breakfast was always noisy.
Not because anyone argued.
Because everyone spoke at the same time.
Her father discussed current affairs.
Her mother reminded us to carry our lunch.
Aashika complained about office work.
I complained about traffic.
By the time breakfast ended...
all of us had laughed at least once.
The bus stop was only a short walk from the house.
Those ten minutes somehow became one of my
favourite parts of the day.
No phones.
No office pressure.
Just two friends walking through the quiet morning
streets.
Some days..
we spoke continuously.
Other days...
we simply walked in silence.
Neither of us ever felt the need to fill every moment
with words.
Comfortable silence had returned to our friendship.
One morning...
she suddenly asked,
"Mithran..."
"Hmm?"
"If you had one crore rupees right now..."
"What would you do?"
I thought for a moment.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

"Travel."

"Only travel?"

"Yes."

"Where?"

I smiled.

"Switzerland."

She laughed.

"I knew you'd say that."

"What about you?"

She looked ahead while walking.

"I think..."

"I'd build a small house."

"Nothing big."

"Just enough."

I smiled.

"That's such an Aashika answer."

"What does that mean?"

"It means..."

"You always choose peace over excitement."

She thought about it.

Then nodded.

"Maybe."

By the time we reached the bus stop...

our bus would usually arrive within a few minutes.

The crowd slowly became familiar.

The same conductor.

The same office employees.

The same college students.

Without realizing it...

we had become part of their everyday routine too.

Our offices were in different parts of the city.

Mine came first.

Hers was a little farther away.
Every morning...
before getting down...
I would look towards her.
"See you tonight."
She would smile.
"Don't get fired."
"I'll try."
"You always say that."
"And you always tell me not to."
"Because someone has to."
Every evening...
the routine happened in reverse.
Whoever finished work first would message the other.
Sometimes it was me.
Sometimes it was her.
One evening...
I was delayed because of a meeting.
When I finally checked my phone...
there were six unread messages.
"Still alive?"
"Meeting?"
"Hello?"
"Don't tell me you're working overtime already."
"Fine."
"I'll leave without you."
I immediately called her.
She answered before the first ring ended.
"So..."
"You remembered me."
"I'm sorry."
"The meeting went longer."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

"I know."

"I was just teasing."

"You left already?"

"No."

"I'm still waiting."

"You waited?"

She sounded surprised.

"Obviously."

"We always go home together."

I smiled without realizing it.

"I'll be there in five minutes."

"You have exactly five."

"If you take six..."

"I'm eating your snacks."

I laughed.

"You always threaten me with food."

"Because it works."

"It actually does."

"I know."

When I reached the bus stop...

she was sitting on a small concrete bench, swinging
her office ID card absentmindedly.

The moment she saw me...

she stood up.

"You took seven minutes."

"I know."

"So..."

"I'm eating your snacks."

I opened my bag.

"You already know I don't carry snacks."

She stared at me.

Then both of us started laughing.

The ride home was always different from the morning.

In the morning...

everyone looked sleepy.

In the evening...

everyone looked tired.

The entire bus was unusually quiet.

Some passengers slept.

Some listened to music.

Some simply stared out of the window.

"What happened today?"

I asked.

She leaned her head against the window.

"My manager gave me three new tasks."

"Only three?"

She looked at me.

"Only?"

"I got six."

She immediately smiled.

"Looks like you're suffering more than me."

"I definitely am."

"Good."

"Why good?"

"Now I don't feel bad."

I laughed.

"There are good friends..."

"And then there's you."

She grinned proudly.

"I know."

As the days passed...

our conversations slowly changed.

We no longer spoke about exams.

Or attendance.
Or assignments.
Instead...
we spoke about deadlines.
Office politics.
Salary.
Career plans.
Dream companies.
Future goals.
Without realizing it...
the two teenagers who once spent hours discussing
college life...
were slowly becoming adults.
Some evenings...
we didn't even feel like talking.
We simply sat beside each other during the bus ride.
Watching Bangalore's traffic crawl through the streets.
Those quiet journeys never felt awkward.
Because some friendships become so comfortable...
that even silence feels like a conversation.
Neither of us knew it then...
but life was quietly preparing us for changes neither
of us could see.
And sometimes...
the happiest days are the ones that feel completely
ordinary while you're living them.
There was something strange about adulthood.
When we were children...
we thought growing up meant having freedom.
During college...
we thought it meant getting a job.
But after we actually started working...

we realized growing up meant something completely different.
It meant responsibility.
It meant making decisions without asking anyone else.
And somehow...
both of us were learning those lessons together.
Weeks slowly became months.
Without realizing it...
our morning walks, bus journeys and evening conversations became part of our lives.
Every day looked almost the same.
Yet...
not a single day felt boring.
Because no matter how tiring work became...
we always had someone waiting at the end of the day.
One Friday evening...
I reached home much earlier than usual.
The house was unusually quiet.
Aunty was watching television.
Uncle hadn't returned from work yet.
Aashika was still at the office.
I kept my bag inside my room and sat in the balcony.
The weather was pleasant.
Dark clouds slowly gathered across the Bangalore sky.
Within a few minutes...
it started raining.
Not heavily.
Just enough to make the roads shine.
Almost half an hour later...
I heard the front gate open.
Aashika entered the house holding her bag over her head, trying to protect herself from the rain.

It clearly hadn't worked.
Her hair was completely wet.
Even the sleeves of her kurti were soaked.
The moment she entered...
her mother looked at her.
"I told you to carry an umbrella."
"I forgot."
"You forget every single time."
"I know..."
She laughed while placing her bag on the sofa.
She noticed me sitting in the balcony.
"So..."
"You escaped the rain."
"I reached early."
"You're lucky."
"I know."
She looked outside.
"I actually like this weather."
"So do I."
For a few minutes...
both of us simply watched the rain.
Neither of us spoke.
Sometimes...
silence is enough when two people are watching the
same view.
That evening...
there was a power cut.
The entire apartment became dark.
Only the sound of rain filled the silence.
Her mother lit a small emergency lamp and placed it
in the middle of the living room.
Suddenly...

everyone gathered there.

No television.

No mobile phones.

No laptops.

Just conversations.

Uncle started telling stories from his college days.

Auntie laughed every time he exaggerated something.

My sister had once told me...

"Every family has stories that become funnier every time they're told."

She was right.

Even though I had already heard some of those stories...

I still laughed.

Not because the stories were new.

Because the people telling them made them feel new.

After dinner...

the rain became heavier.

"We're definitely not getting any power tonight."

Uncle said while looking outside.

Aashika smiled.

"Good."

"At least nobody can ask me to check office emails."

Everyone laughed.

She looked at me.

"What about your office?"

"My manager will survive without me for one night."

"I hope so."

"If not..."

"I'll say there was no electricity."

She laughed.

"That's actually believable."

The lights finally returned almost an hour later.

One by one...

everyone went back to their rooms.

Before sleeping...

Aashika knocked on my door.

"Are you awake?"

"Yeah."

She stood at the door.

Holding two packets of biscuits.

She threw one towards me.

"You forgot to buy snacks."

I caught it.

Then laughed.

"So this is why you bought two?"

She smiled proudly.

"I knew you'd be hungry."

I looked at the biscuit packet for a second.

Then looked back at her.

"You always think ahead."

"I have to."

"You don't."

"I do."

"Otherwise who'll remind you to eat?"

I shook my head while smiling.

"Thank you."

She shrugged casually.

"Don't make it emotional."

"It's just biscuits."

But somehow...

it wasn't just biscuits.

It was another small reminder...

that some people care without making a big deal about it.

Months continued to pass.

Festivals came and went.

Birthdays were celebrated.

Promotions were discussed.

Salary credits became exciting.

Weekend grocery shopping somehow became an adventure.

Sometimes we argued about which movie to watch.

Sometimes we spent entire Sundays doing absolutely nothing.

Those ordinary days quietly became extraordinary memories.

One Sunday morning...

we both decided to clean the storeroom.

There were old boxes everywhere.

Dust covered almost everything.

She looked at one old cardboard box and smiled.

"Remember this?"

"What?"

She opened it.

Inside were a few old board games.

Some childhood toys.

And a broken badminton racket.

I laughed.

"I thought this was lost."

"So did I."

She picked up the racket.

"You used to think you were a professional player."

"I still do."

"No..."

"You were terrible."

"I won against you."

"Once."

"It still counts."

She rolled her eyes.

"It doesn't."

The cleaning continued for another hour.

By the time we finished...

both of us were covered in dust.

She looked at my shirt and started laughing.

"What?"

"You should see yourself."

I looked down.

My shirt had turned almost grey.

I laughed too.

"You don't look any better."

Her cheeks had a small streak of dust.

Without thinking...

I pointed towards it.

"You've got something..."

She quickly wiped the wrong side of her face.

"No..."

"The other side."

She tried again.

Still wrong.

I couldn't stop laughing.

"What?"

"You're making it worse."

She looked annoyed.

"Then stop laughing and tell me."

I handed her my phone.

"Use the camera."

She looked at herself.
Then immediately burst into laughter.
"I've been walking around like this?"
"For the last five minutes."
"Idiot."
"You could've told me earlier."
"I was enjoying the show."
She hit my shoulder lightly.
Both of us laughed until our stomachs hurt.
That night...
while lying on my bed...
I realized something.
Nothing extraordinary had happened today.
No grand trip.
No celebration.
No surprise.
Just rain.
Family conversations.
Cleaning an old room.
Laughing over dust.
Sharing a packet of biscuits.
Yet somehow...
it had become one of the happiest days of the year.
Maybe happiness was never hidden inside
extraordinary moments.
Maybe...
it had always been hiding inside ordinary days spent
with the right people.

Chapter Twenty-Eight

Different Dreams

Almost six months had passed since both of us started working.
Life had settled into a comfortable routine.
Weekdays belonged to work.
Weekends belonged to family.
And whenever we found a little free time...
we spent it talking about everything that had happened during the week.
Sometimes...
our conversations lasted only fifteen minutes.
Sometimes...
they continued until midnight.
Nothing had changed.
At least...
that's what I believed.
One evening...
we were returning home after work.
The bus was unusually crowded.
Both of us managed to find seats near the window.
For a while...
neither of us spoke.
Both of us looked tired.
She suddenly smiled while looking at her phone.
I noticed it.
Not because I was trying to.
Because the smile reminded me of someone who had just read something funny.

"What happened?"

I asked.

She looked up immediately.

"Hmm?"

"You smiled."

"Oh..."

She laughed.

"Our team group."

"What now?"

"One of my teammates accidentally sent a meme to our manager instead of our friends' group."

I couldn't stop laughing.

"What happened then?"

"Our manager replied with another meme."

"No way."

"I'm serious."

She showed me the chat.

Even I started laughing.

"Your manager seems cool."

"He actually is."

"What about the rest of your team?"

She thought for a moment.

"They're nice."

"Most of them."

"There's one girl who talks non-stop."

"Another one who keeps forgetting deadlines."

"And..."

She stopped.

"And?"

"There is one guy."

"What about him?"

"Nothing."

"He's just really helpful."

I nodded.

That was all.

The conversation continued.

I didn't think about it again.

Over the next few weeks...

his name started appearing more often.

Not every day.

Not in every conversation.

Just...

occasionally.

"Today he helped me finish a presentation."

"Today our whole team went out for lunch."

"He always makes everyone laugh."

"He explained something I couldn't understand."

I listened to everything.

The same way I always had.

Without interrupting.

Without judging.

Without asking unnecessary questions.

One Sunday afternoon...

both of us were helping Uncle wash the car
downstairs.

She was spraying water while I wiped the windows.

Suddenly...

her phone rang.

She looked at the screen.

"It's from the office."

She answered immediately.

I continued cleaning.

Without paying attention.

The conversation lasted almost ten minutes.

When she returned...

I smiled.

"Weekend meeting?"

"No."

She laughed.

"He wanted one file."

"Forgot to take it yesterday."

"Oh."

"That's all."

Life continued.

A few months later...

her office announced a team outing.

The entire department was going to Mysore for two days.

She looked surprisingly excited.

"I've never been on an office trip before."

"You'll enjoy it."

"I hope so."

"You definitely will."

She smiled.

"I'll bring something for you."

"You don't have to."

"I know."

"But I will."

The trip lasted two days.

The house felt strangely quiet without her.

Even Auntie admitted it.

"This house becomes too silent when she's not here."

Uncle smiled.

"That's because she talks enough for all of us."

Everyone laughed.

On Sunday evening...

she finally returned.
The moment she entered the house...
she looked exhausted.
But happy.
"How was it?"
I asked.
She dropped her backpack onto the sofa.
"My legs are dead."
"That means it was fun."
"It really was."
She sat beside me.
Then spent almost an hour telling me everything.
The bus journey.
The hotel.
The sightseeing.
The funny games.
Who got lost.
Who couldn't wake up in the morning.
Who almost missed the bus.
While speaking...
she laughed more than I had seen in weeks.
I simply sat there...
listening.
Sometimes asking questions.
Sometimes laughing with her.
Then she suddenly showed me a group photo.
"There..."
she pointed.
"That's my whole team."
I looked carefully.
Around fifteen people.
Standing together.

Smiling at the camera.
She pointed again.
"And that's the person I told you about."
I looked.
A tall guy.
Standing somewhere in the last row.
Smiling naturally.
Nothing special.
Just another colleague.
"He looks friendly."
"He is."
She smiled.
"He's one of the nicest people in our office."
I nodded.
"That's good."
She locked her phone.
The conversation naturally moved on to something else.
That night...
while lying on my bed...
I thought about the group photo.
Not because I was worried.
Not because I was jealous.
Simply because...
for the first time...
I had started seeing the people who had become part of her everyday life.
College had introduced us to each other.
Now...
work was introducing her to new people.
And that...
was completely normal.

Somewhere inside me...
I quietly reminded myself...
Life keeps moving.
People keep meeting new people.
That doesn't mean they forget the old ones.
I smiled.
Closed my eyes.
And slowly drifted to sleep.
Looking back now...
I think life has its own way of preparing us for
change.
It never happens in a single day.
It happens so slowly that you don't even notice it
while you're living through it.
That's exactly what happened to us.
Our friendship remained exactly the same.
We still travelled together whenever our office
timings matched. We still shared almost everything
that happened during the day. We still celebrated
birthdays together, argued over silly things, and
laughed at the same old jokes that no one else would
understand.
If someone had seen us during those days...
they would've never guessed that our lives were
slowly moving towards different destinations.
As months passed, Aashika became more
comfortable in her workplace.
During the first few weeks, she used to come home
tired and confused. Every day was something new for
her. New responsibilities. New people. New
expectations.
But slowly...

that nervousness disappeared.
She became more confident.
Her stories changed too.
Instead of talking about how difficult work was, she
started talking about people.
Her teammates.
Her manager.
Office celebrations.
Birthday parties.
Team lunches.
Projects that kept everyone awake until late evening.
Listening to those stories somehow reminded me of
our college days.
The only difference was...
this wasn't college anymore.
This was life.
Among all those stories...
one person slowly became a regular character.
At first, I never noticed it.
She would casually mention his name while explaining
something that had happened at work.
Sometimes he had helped her complete a
presentation.
Sometimes he had stayed back after office hours to
finish a project with the team.
Sometimes he had simply made everyone laugh
during stressful days.
To me...
he was just another colleague.
Nothing more.
There was something I had learned after June 22.
Trust.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

Real trust.
It meant allowing someone to have a life beyond you.
I never wanted to become the kind of person who
questioned every friendship or every smile.
She deserved the freedom to build her own world.
And I genuinely wanted her to.
One Saturday evening...
both of us were sitting on the terrace after dinner.
The weather was unusually pleasant.
The city lights stretched endlessly in front of us.
Neither of us was speaking much.
Those moments had become common between us.
Silence had finally become comfortable.
After a long pause...
she suddenly spoke.
"Mithran..."
'There was something different in her voice.
Not fear.
Not sadness.
Just uncertainty.
I turned towards her.
"Hmm?"
She looked down at her hands.
"I want to ask you something."
I smiled.
"When have you ever needed permission?"
She laughed softly.
Then became serious again.
"What would you do..."
"If you started liking someone?"
I didn't answer immediately.
Instead...

I asked her another question.
"Is this question really about me?"
She slowly looked up.
A small smile appeared on her face.
"You know me too well."
At that moment...
I understood.
Not everything.
But enough.
She didn't rush to explain.
She took her time.
Maybe because she herself was still trying to
understand what she was feeling.
She told me how they had become friends over the
past few months.
It hadn't happened suddenly.
There was no dramatic moment.
No movie-like confession.
It had simply started with work.
Helping each other.
Sharing responsibilities.
Talking during lunch breaks.
Laughing over small mistakes.
Somewhere in between...
friendship had quietly become something more.
As she spoke...
I simply listened.
I didn't interrupt.
I didn't ask unnecessary questions.
I didn't judge.
For years...

she had trusted me with every important decision in her life.

This wasn't the moment to make it about myself.

After she finished speaking...

she looked at me with the same expression she had carried after telling me about her first relationship years ago.

She wasn't asking for permission.

She was asking for honesty.

"Mithran..."

"What do you think?"

That question stayed in my mind for a long time.

Even today...

I can remember those few seconds of silence.

Because in those few seconds...

I had two choices.

I could answer as the boy who loved her.

Or...

I could answer as the friend she trusted the most.

I chose the second one.

I smiled.

"If he makes you smile the way you're smiling right now..."

"I think you already know your answer."

She looked at me for a few seconds.

Then smiled.

A smile so genuine...

that I immediately understood something.

She was happy.

And strangely...

seeing her happy made me happy too.

People often think acceptance means the absence of pain.
It doesn't.
There was pain.
A quiet pain that only I knew.
But alongside that pain...
there was something else.
Peace.
Because loving someone also means wanting them to find happiness...
even if that happiness doesn't have your name written on it.
That night...
I couldn't sleep immediately.
Not because my heart was broken.
But because it had finally accepted something it had known for years.
Some people enter our lives to stay forever.
Some enter our lives to change us forever.
Aashika had done both.
She had stayed.
Not as the person I would marry.
But as the person who had unknowingly taught me what unconditional love looked like.
Looking back now...
think that conversation on the terrace wasn't the day I lost the girl I loved.
It was the day I stopped waiting for life to become something it was never meant to be.
And surprisingly...
my heart felt lighter after that.
After that evening...

nothing really changed.
At least, not on the outside.
We still woke up at the same time.
We still walked to the bus stop together.
We still shared stories about our day over dinner.
We still laughed at the smallest things.
If someone had looked at us from the outside...
they would have thought nothing had changed.
But inside me...
something had become calmer.
For years, I had silently carried a dream that I never
spoke about.
Now...
that dream had quietly turned into a memory.
Oddly enough...
it didn't hurt as much as I thought it would.
Maybe because I had already accepted the truth long
before she said it aloud.
Life never waits for us to finish one chapter before
beginning another.
A few months later...
I received an email that I had been waiting for.
My application for a Master's degree in Australia had
been accepted.
I read the email three times before believing it.
For a long time, studying abroad had remained
nothing more than a distant dream.
Now...
it had suddenly become real.
When I told my parents...
they were happier than I was.

My mother immediately started asking practical questions.

"When will you leave?"

"What should we pack?"

"Have you checked your passport?"

My father smiled quietly.

He didn't say much.

But I could see the pride in his eyes.

That evening...

I told Aashika.

She stared at me for a few seconds before speaking.

"Australia?"

I nodded.

"Looks like you're finally leaving all of us."

I laughed.

"I'm only going to study."

"I'll come back."

She smiled.

"I know."

"But it's still very far."

"It is."

For a moment...

both of us became quiet.

Not because we were sad.

Because we were trying to imagine a life where our daily routines no longer included each other.

The weeks that followed became surprisingly busy.

Passport verification.

University documents.

Shopping.

Visa appointments.

Packing.

Every day brought another task to complete.
Sometimes I felt more like a traveller than a student.
To my surprise...
Aashika became more excited than I was.
Every evening she would ask,
"So...
what's left?"
If I said,
"Nothing."
She would immediately find something.
"Did you buy an adapter?"
"Did you check the baggage limit?"
"What about winter clothes?"
I laughed more than once.
"You've become my personal checklist."
She smiled proudly.
"Someone has to save you."
One Sunday...
she came into the living room carrying a notebook.
"I made a list."
"A list?"
"For Australia."
She handed it to me.
It wasn't a complicated document.
Just a few handwritten pages.
Things not to forget.
Emergency numbers.
Medicine reminders.
Food suggestions.
Simple Tamil phrases translated into English in case I
needed them.
Even a reminder to call home every weekend.

I looked at her.

"You actually wrote all this?"

She shrugged casually.

"I was bored."

I laughed.

"No."

"You were caring."

She looked away immediately.

"Don't make it emotional."

"I'm serious."

She smiled without saying anything.

I carefully folded the paper and placed it inside my passport cover.

I still don't know if she ever realised how much that simple list meant to me.

The closer my departure came...

the more I started appreciating ordinary moments.

Watching television together after dinner.

Walking to the nearby shop.

Listening to Uncle's stories.

Helping Auntie bring groceries upstairs.

Weekend family lunches.

For years...

I had thought memorable moments were created by special occasions.

Looking back...

I realised they were hidden inside ordinary days.

The night before my flight...

none of us slept early.

Suitcases stood near the door.

Documents were checked one final time.

Everyone pretended to be relaxed.

Nobody really was.
Around midnight...
I stepped onto the balcony for some fresh air.
The city was unusually quiet.
A few minutes later...
I heard the balcony door open behind me.
It was Aashika.
She stood beside me without saying anything.
For a while...
both of us simply looked at the lights spread across
Bangalore.
Finally...
she spoke.
"It's strange."
"What?"
"You've stayed here for so long..."
"And tomorrow this room will be empty."
I smiled.
"It won't stay empty forever."
"I know."
"But it'll be different."
I nodded.
"So will Australia."
She looked at me and smiled.
"You'll do well there."
"I hope so."
"No..."
she corrected gently.
"I know so."
That sentence stayed with me long after she went
back inside.
Sometimes...

confidence borrowed from someone who believes in us becomes stronger than confidence we have in ourselves.

The next morning...

everyone came to the airport.

My parents.

My sister.

Aunty.

Uncle.

And Aashika.

The airport was crowded.

Announcements echoed through the terminal every few minutes.

People hugged.

People cried.

People smiled.

Everywhere I looked...

someone was saying goodbye.

When it was finally time for me to leave...

I hugged Uncle.

Then Aunty.

My parents.

My sister.

Finally...

I stood in front of Aashika.

For a second...

neither of us spoke.

Then she smiled.

Not the smile of someone saying goodbye forever.

The smile of someone waiting for the next conversation.

"Don't forget us."

she said softly.

I smiled.

"I couldn't...

even if I wanted to."

She laughed.

"Call after you land."

"I will."

"And don't skip meals."

I laughed.

"You'll never stop reminding me, will you?"

"Never."

We both smiled.

I picked up my backpack.

Walked towards immigration.

Halfway there...

I turned around.

Everyone was still standing exactly where I had left them.

They waved.

I waved back.

Then I walked forward.

I didn't know what Australia would give me.

I only knew one thing.

No matter how far I travelled...

some people would always remain home.

Chapter Twenty-Nine

A New Beginning for Him

The flight felt endless.
For almost twelve hours, I kept switching between
sleeping, watching movies, and staring outside the
small window beside me.
At some point...
India disappeared beneath the clouds.
Then there was nothing.
Just an endless sky.
For the first time in my life...
I was travelling so far away from home.
Not for a vacation.
Not to meet relatives.
But to build a future.
Looking back now...
I don't think I was excited.
I was scared.
Scared of a new country.
Scared of living alone.
Scared of beginning again.
When the aircraft finally landed...
everything felt unfamiliar.
The airport was larger than anything I had seen
before.
The announcements sounded different.
People walked faster.
Even the weather felt strange.
Cold air welcomed me the moment I stepped outside.

I immediately understood something.
This wasn't Bangalore.
This wasn't Trichy.
This was an entirely different life.
The university had arranged accommodation for international students.
A bus picked us up from the airport and dropped us at the campus.
As I looked outside the window...
wide roads stretched endlessly.
The buildings looked different.
The traffic was quieter.
Everything seemed organised.
Yet...
something was missing.
Home.
My room was small.
A single bed.
A study table.
A cupboard.
A window facing a quiet street.
That was all.
I placed my suitcase near the bed and sat down.
For the first time in many years...
there was complete silence around me.
No Uncle reading the newspaper.
No Aunty calling everyone for dinner.
No Aashika complaining about work.
No familiar voices.
Only silence.
That evening...
I finally understood what loneliness sounded like.

The first few weeks were difficult.
Cooking was an adventure.
Sometimes the rice became too soft.
Sometimes it remained half-cooked.
I watched countless videos trying to make simple meals.
Most of them failed.
Whenever I looked at the burnt pan...
I remembered Aunty laughing at me in Bangalore.
"One day you'll learn."
She had been right.
I eventually did.
Laundry was another challenge.
Back home...
I never paid attention to how many small things happened automatically.
Now...
every small task depended on me.
Cleaning the room.
Buying groceries.
Managing expenses.
Cooking.
Studying.
Everything.
At first...
it felt overwhelming.
Later...
it became routine.
Classes began the following week.
Students had come from different parts of the world.
Different languages.
Different cultures.

Different dreams.
Yet...
all of us shared one thing.
We had left home to build a future.
That somehow made us understand each other
without saying much.
Every evening...
after returning to my room...
I followed the same routine.
I cooked dinner.
Finished my assignments.
Then called home.
Some days I spoke to my parents.
Some days to my sister.
Some days...
Aashika answered the video call because she
happened to be visiting my parents or they were
visiting her family.
Nothing felt forced.
Nothing felt awkward.
She would ask the same questions every time.
"Did you eat?"
"How's the weather?"
"Are you wearing warm clothes?"
"Are you sleeping properly?"
Every single time...
I gave the same answers.
"Yes."
Even when the answer was sometimes "No."
Because I knew she'd worry.
Slowly...
the homesickness became easier to carry.

Not because I stopped missing home.
But because I learned to live alongside that feeling.
Some evenings I would walk around the campus after
class.
The sky looked different there.
The sunsets lasted longer.
The air felt colder.
I often sat alone on a wooden bench near a small lake
inside the university.
Watching ducks swim peacefully across the water.
It became my favourite place.
Whenever life felt overwhelming...
I came back there.
Looking back now...
I think those quiet evenings changed me more than
any classroom ever did.
For the first time...
I wasn't someone's son.
Someone's cousin.
Someone's best friend.
Someone's employee.
I was simply...
Mithran.
Trying to understand who he wanted to become.
As the months passed...
my confidence slowly grew.
I became comfortable speaking with classmates.
Group assignments no longer felt stressful.
Professors started recognising me.
The campus that once felt unfamiliar...
slowly started feeling like home.
Not the home I had left behind.

But a new one.

One afternoon...

our professor announced a semester-long research project.

Students were asked to form teams of two.

The classroom immediately filled with conversations.

Everyone began looking for partners.

I quietly picked up my notebook.

Before I could ask anyone...

a voice came from behind me.

"Are you still looking for a partner?"

I turned around.

A girl stood there.

She smiled politely.

"I don't have one either."

For a second...

I simply smiled back.

"I guess..."

"So now we both do."

Looking back now...

I had no idea that such an ordinary conversation...
would quietly begin the next chapter of my life.

When I first met her...

I didn't think much about it.

She was simply another student trying to survive assignments, deadlines and presentations, just like everyone else in our class.

If someone had told me that day that she would later become my wife...

I probably would've laughed.

Life has a strange habit of introducing important people in the most ordinary ways.

Our first project lasted almost three months.
During those weeks, we met almost every day.
Sometimes inside the library.
Sometimes in empty classrooms after lectures.
Sometimes in the campus study hall that remained open until midnight.
Most of our conversations were about the project itself.
Research.
Presentations.
Deadlines.
Nothing more.
There was one thing I noticed about her.
She never spoke unnecessarily.
Whenever she had something to say...
she said it clearly.
Whenever she didn't...
she was perfectly comfortable with silence.
That reminded me of something.
Not someone.
Something.
The comfort of silence.
For years...
I had believed that silence only existed between people who understood each other.
Meeting her reminded me that sometimes...
silence simply meant peace.
Unlike me...
she loved coffee.
Every evening after class, she would stop at the small café near the university library before beginning our project work.

The first time she asked,

"Coffee?"

I smiled and shook my head.

"I don't drink coffee."

She looked surprised.

"Tea?"

"No."

"Hot chocolate?"

I laughed.

"No."

She looked genuinely confused.

"So... what do you drink?"

"Mostly water."

She stared at me for a second before laughing.

"I've never met someone like you."

I smiled.

"I hear that a lot."

From that day onwards...

without asking...

she would always bring herself a coffee.

And for me...

a bottle of water or sometimes a fruit juice.

It was a very small gesture.

But somehow...

it never went unnoticed.

Months passed.

The project slowly became a friendship.

We started speaking about things beyond academics.

She asked about India.

About my family.

About the food I missed the most.

About festivals.

About why I smiled whenever someone mentioned home.

I answered every question honestly.

Not because I enjoyed talking about myself.

But because she listened without interrupting.

Without judging.

Without trying to fix anything.

She simply listened.

And sometimes...

that's all a person really needs.

One evening...

while walking back from the library...

she suddenly asked,

"Do you miss home?"

I smiled.

"Every day."

"Then why did you come so far?"

I looked up at the evening sky.

Because honestly...

I had asked myself the same question many times.

"I came here to build a future."

I replied.

"But I think..."

"I found myself instead."

She didn't say anything.

She simply smiled.

Some conversations don't need replies.

Around the same time...

my friendship with Aashika remained exactly the same.

Distance had changed our time zones.

Not our conversations.

Whenever both of us found time...
we still called each other.
Sometimes once a week.
Sometimes twice.
Sometimes only through messages.
But somehow...
it never felt like we had grown apart.
One Saturday morning...
my phone rang.
It was Aashika.
She looked tired.
But happy.
She had just returned from an office trip.
For almost an hour...
she spoke continuously.
I listened exactly the way I always had.
Some habits never change.
Somewhere during that conversation...
she mentioned him again.
The same colleague.
Only this time...
his name appeared more naturally.
Not because she wanted to talk about him.
Because he had quietly become part of her everyday
life.
Looking back...
I think that's when I understood.
She wasn't just happy at work anymore.
She was happy because of the people around her too.
And strangely...
that thought didn't hurt me.
Instead...

it gave me peace.
A few weeks later...
she called me again.
This time...
her voice sounded different.
There was excitement hidden beneath her
nervousness.
"I think..."
"I finally know."
She said.
I smiled even before she finished.
"Knew what?"
She laughed softly.
"I like him."
Those three words stayed in the silence between us.
Years earlier...
I would've broken.
Years earlier...
I would've spent the entire night overthinking.
But life had changed me.
Australia had changed me.
Distance had changed me.
Most importantly...
love had changed me.
I smiled.
Not because I was pretending.
Because I genuinely meant it.
"I'm happy for you."
There was silence.
Then she softly asked,
"You really mean that?"
"I do."

"I've never heard you lie this badly."

I laughed.

"I'm serious."

"I've seen you smile while talking about him."

"I've heard the happiness in your voice."

"If someone can make you feel like that..."

"I don't think I have any reason to be unhappy."

She didn't speak for a while.

Then...

very quietly...

she said,

"Thank you."

That night...

I walked back to my room alone.

The campus was unusually quiet.

Cold wind moved gently through the trees.

I sat on my favourite bench near the lake.

Exactly where I had spent so many evenings during the past year.

I looked at the water for a long time.

Then...

without even realizing it...

I smiled.

Love hadn't left my heart.

It had simply changed its place.

I no longer loved her hoping that one day she would become mine.

I loved her the way you silently wish happiness for someone who once became an important part of your life.

Looking back now...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

I think that was the night I truly understood the
difference between loving someone...
and wanting to possess them.
For the first time...
those two things no longer felt the same
Looking back now...
I think people often misunderstand what moving on
really means.
They think one day you wake up...
and suddenly stop loving someone.
Life doesn't work like that.
At least...
mine never did.
Moving on wasn't forgetting Aashika.
It was allowing myself to continue living without
expecting life to return to the way it once was.
The semester slowly became busier.
Assignments started replacing free evenings.
Presentations became a weekly routine.
Weekdays disappeared before I even realised they had
begun.
Somehow...
I found myself enjoying this new life.
Not because Australia had become home.
But because I had finally stopped comparing
everything with home.
My project partner slowly became one of my closest
friends.
It wasn't something either of us planned.
It simply happened.
Sometimes we studied together until the library
closed.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

Sometimes we walked back to our apartments
discussing nothing related to university.
She had an unusual way of making ordinary
conversations interesting.
One day she would talk about travelling.
The next day she would spend twenty minutes
explaining why sunsets looked different during winter.
Somehow...
she found beauty in things I had stopped noticing.
She also noticed things about me.
Not the big things.
The small ones.
She realised I always arrived ten minutes early.
She realised I never interrupted people while they
were speaking.
She realised I smiled more while listening than while
talking.
And eventually...
she noticed something else.
Whenever someone asked me about my life...
I always spoke about my family.
About India.
About my childhood.
But I never spoke much about myself.
One afternoon...
after finishing a presentation...
we decided to walk through a nearby park before
returning to campus.
It had become autumn.
The leaves had started changing colours.
Everything looked different from the Australia I had
first arrived in.

As we walked...
she suddenly asked,
"Can I ask you something?"
I nodded.
"Of course."
She looked ahead instead of looking at me.
"You've told me so much about your family."
"You've told me about your hometown."
"You've even told me funny stories from school."
She smiled.
"But..."
"I've never heard you talk about someone you loved."
For a second...
I smiled.
Not because the question surprised me.
Because I knew...
one day someone would eventually ask it.
I didn't answer immediately.
Instead...
I sat down on a nearby bench.
The wind quietly carried dry leaves across the path.
People walked past us without paying attention.
The world continued exactly as it always had.
"There was someone."
I finally said.
"I never told her."
"At least..."
"Not the way people usually confess."
"It remained inside me."
"For a very long time."
She didn't interrupt.
She simply listened.

Exactly the way I had listened to Aashika years ago.

"I thought life would be very different."

I continued.

"But sometimes..."

"Life chooses a better ending than the one we imagine."

She smiled gently.

"Did you ever regret not telling her?"

I thought about that question for a long time.

Years ago...

my answer would've been different.

Now...

it wasn't.

"I regret the expectations."

I replied honestly.

"Not the love."

She looked at me quietly.

"What do you mean?"

I smiled.

"When you truly love someone..."

"You don't regret loving them."

"You only regret expecting life to happen exactly the way you imagined."

She nodded slowly.

Almost as though she understood without needing another explanation.

That conversation ended there.

Neither of us mentioned it again.

But strangely...

after that day...

our friendship changed.

Not dramatically.

Not overnight.
It simply became deeper.
There was more trust.
More comfort.
More understanding.
Months turned into another year.
Without noticing...
we had become part of each other's everyday lives.
She became the first person I shared good news with
after calling
my parents.
I became the person she called whenever she
achieved something important.
We celebrated birthdays.
Finished another semester.
Travelled with our classmates during university
holidays.
Collected photographs that later became beautiful
memories.
One evening...
while walking back after class...
she suddenly laughed.
"What?"
I asked.
"You know..."
"When I first met you..."
"I thought you were the most serious person in the
class."
I laughed.
"And now?"
She smiled.
"Now I know..."

"You're just a good listener."

I looked at the sky.

The sun was slowly disappearing behind the buildings.

For a brief moment...

I remembered another city.

Another sunset.

Another person who once said...

"I know you."

I smiled. Not because I missed the past.

But because I realised something.

Life never replaces people.

It introduces new ones.

Each person teaches us something different.

Aashika had taught me how deeply a heart could love.

This girl was quietly teaching me...

that a healed heart could love again without forgetting
its first story. And perhaps...

that was never betrayal.

Perhaps...

that was simply life moving forward.

Chapter Thirty

If It Waits

Life became surprisingly peaceful after graduation. Australia slowly became more than just the country where I studied. It became the place where I learnt how to live on my own.

The university campus that once felt unfamiliar had become part of my daily routine. Assignments slowly disappeared, internships became jobs, and somewhere in between, I realised that I was no longer the boy who had left Bangalore carrying two suitcases and a heart full of uncertainty.

I had changed.

Not completely.

Just enough.

Lily had become an important part of that journey.

Our friendship had grown naturally over the years.

There was no dramatic confession.

No grand proposal.

No moment where everything suddenly changed.

Instead...

there were hundreds of ordinary days.

Studying together.

Walking through the campus after class.

Celebrating birthdays with friends.

Supporting each other during difficult times.

Somewhere between those ordinary moments...

our friendship quietly became love.

It wasn't the kind of love that arrived like a storm.

It arrived like sunrise.

Slowly.

Peacefully.

Without asking for attention.

One evening...

while we were preparing dinner together, my phone started ringing.

The screen showed a familiar name.

Aashika.

I smiled before answering.

Lily noticed it immediately.

"You should take that."

I nodded and answered the call.

The conversation began exactly the way all our conversations usually began.

She asked whether I had eaten.

I asked about work.

She complained about deadlines.

I complained about the weather.

Nothing unusual.

Nothing different.

Just two friends continuing a conversation that had lasted for years.

Then...

her voice became quieter.

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"I have something important to tell you."

I smiled.

"What happened?"

There was a short pause.

Then she laughed nervously.

"My marriage has been fixed."
For a brief moment...
I closed my eyes.
Not because I was hurt.
Because I knew this moment would eventually come.
Somewhere deep inside...
I had been preparing for this conversation for years.
When I finally opened my eyes...
I was smiling.
"Genuinely?"
"Yes."
"I'm really happy for you."
"I knew you'd say that."
She laughed.
She told me everything.
How both families had met.
How everyone liked each other.
How nervous she had been.
How excited her parents were.
She sounded...
happy.
That was enough.
Before ending the call, she said,
"You have to come."
"I will."
"No excuses."
"I wasn't planning to make any."
"And..."
She hesitated.
"You have to bring Lily too."
I smiled.
"I think she'd love that."

"I already know she will."

When the call ended...

Lily looked at me curiously.

"So..."

"Wedding?"

I nodded.

"Aashika."

Lily smiled warmly.

"Then we're going."

I looked at her.

"So easily?"

She laughed.

"Why wouldn't we?"

"You've told me so much about your family."

"I finally get to meet them."

"And..."

She smiled mischievously.

"I finally get to meet the famous Aashika."

I couldn't stop laughing.

"Famous?"

"You've mentioned her in enough stories."

"I feel like I already know her."

A few weeks later...

we boarded another flight.

This time...

I wasn't travelling alone.

As the aircraft took off...

Lily looked outside the window with the excitement
of a child.

"This is my first time visiting India."

I smiled.

"I know."

"You'll love it."

During the journey...

I found myself remembering another flight.

Years ago...

I had travelled in the opposite direction.

Leaving India.

Leaving home.

Leaving the people who had shaped my life.

Now...

I was returning.

Not because I belonged there anymore.

But because someone important had invited me to
witness one of the happiest days of her life.

When we landed in Bangalore...

the warm air immediately reminded me that I was
home.

Not permanently.

But emotionally.

Some places never stop feeling familiar.

Uncle and Auntie were waiting outside the airport.

The moment they saw me...

their smiles became wider.

"Mithran!"

Uncle hugged me tightly.

"So Australia finally sent you back."

I laughed.

"Only for a few days."

Then he looked towards Lily.

"So this must be Lily."

She smiled politely.

"Vanakkam."

She had practised that single word for almost two weeks.

Everyone immediately laughed.

Aunty hugged her warmly.

"Welcome to our family."

Lily looked at me and whispered,

"I think they already adopted me."

I smiled.

"I told you."

On the drive home...

Lily spent almost the entire journey looking outside the window.

Everything fascinated her.

The traffic.

The street vendors.

The colourful shops.

The small temples beside the roads.

She asked questions about almost everything.

Uncle patiently answered every one of them.

By the time we reached home...

she already felt like part of the family.

The house looked exactly the way I remembered it.

Except now...

it was filled with wedding decorations.

Gift boxes covered one corner of the living room.

Flower samples lay across the dining table.

Relatives walked in and out carrying bags.

The entire house was alive.

As I stepped inside...

I heard a familiar voice from upstairs.

"Amma... where did you keep those invitation covers?"

A few seconds later...
she came downstairs.
For a moment...
both of us simply looked at each other.
It had been a long time.
She smiled first.
"You actually came."
I laughed.
"I promised."
Then...
her eyes moved towards Lily.
"You must be Lily."
Lily smiled warmly.
"And you must be Aashika."
They shook hands.
Within five minutes...
they were already talking as though they had known
each other for years.
I quietly stood there watching both of them laugh.
Lily suddenly looked at Aashika and asked,
"So..."
"Does he still forget to eat when he's busy?"
Aashika immediately laughed.
"Every single time."
I sighed dramatically.
"I can't believe both of you teamed up within five
minutes."
Both of them looked at each other...
and laughed even harder.
For the first time...
I realised something.
The two most important chapters of my life...

had finally met each other.
The next few days passed so quickly that none of us
even noticed how close the wedding had become.
From early morning until late at night...
the house never became quiet.
Relatives kept arriving one after another.
Some had travelled from different cities.
Some had come from different states.
Every room was occupied.
Every corner of the house was filled with luggage,
laughter and
conversations.
It reminded me of my childhood.
Back then...
family functions weren't about ceremonies.
They were about everyone living under the same roof
for a few days.
No one slept on time.
No one woke up on time either.
Yet somehow...
everyone enjoyed every minute of it.
Lily adapted much faster than I expected.
Within a day...
she had already become everyone's favourite.
Aunty taught her how to wear a saree.
My mother tried introducing her to different South
Indian dishes.
Uncle proudly explained every wedding tradition to
her as though he were giving a lecture.
She listened to everything with genuine curiosity.
Every new experience fascinated her.
Sometimes she would quietly ask me questions.

"What does this ceremony mean?"

"Why is everyone putting flowers everywhere?"

"Why are there so many sweets?"

I answered every question patiently.

Sometimes even I had to ask Uncle before answering her.

He would smile proudly and explain every ritual in detail.

Looking at Lily trying to understand our traditions somehow made me appreciate them even more.

Meanwhile...

Aashika had almost no time to sit down.

Every hour someone needed her.

Sometimes it was the photographer.

Sometimes the makeup artist.

Sometimes relatives.

Sometimes wedding shopping.

She walked from one room to another carrying lists in her hand, trying to make sure nothing was forgotten.

I had seen her stressed before.

During exams.

During office deadlines.

During family functions.

But this was different.

This wasn't stress.

It was excitement mixed with responsibility.

Naturally...

I did whatever work I could.

Somebody needed flowers from the market.

I went.

Someone had to collect the invitation cards.

I went.

Someone forgot a decoration item.

I went again.

At one point...

Uncle looked at me and laughed.

"You came here as a guest."

"But you're working harder than everyone."

I smiled.

"I've never really been a guest here."

He placed his hand on my shoulder.

"No."

"You never were."

Those words stayed with me.

Some relationships never need names.

They simply become family.

One afternoon...

Aashika's sister asked me to help arrange the return gifts for the guests.

Hundreds of small gift bags covered the living room floor.

Lily immediately sat beside us and started helping.

Within a few minutes...

all three of us were folding bags, tying ribbons and checking names.

The work was repetitive.

But somehow...

it became enjoyable because of the conversations happening around us.

Someone would tell an old family story.

Someone else would interrupt with a completely different version.

Nobody agreed on what had actually happened years ago.

Yet everyone laughed.
At one point...
Aashika walked into the room carrying another box.
She looked exhausted.
Without saying anything...
she sat down beside us.
For almost five minutes...
none of us spoke.
We simply continued arranging the gift bags.
Finally...
she looked at me.
"I forgot how tiring weddings are."
I laughed.
"You haven't even reached the wedding day yet."
"Don't remind me."
Lily smiled.
"I think you're doing amazingly."
Aashika looked at her.
"Really?"
"Of course."
"I'd probably panic if I had to organise something this big."
Aashika smiled gratefully.
"Thank you."
Later that evening...
all of us went to the wedding hall.
The decorators were still working.
Fresh jasmine flowers filled the entire entrance with their fragrance.
Electric lights stretched across the ceiling.
Workers hurried from one corner to another carrying chairs and decorations.

The hall still looked incomplete.

Yet...

I could already imagine how beautiful it would look the next morning.

Lily walked slowly around the stage.

Everything fascinated her.

She had attended weddings before.

But nothing like this.

She watched the decorators carefully placing every flower by hand.

She looked at the traditional lamps near the entrance.

She admired the colourful rangoli being drawn at the doorway.

"It feels..."

she paused for a moment.

"...alive."

I smiled.

"Indian weddings usually are."

She laughed.

"I can see that."

While everyone else discussed decorations...

I quietly walked onto the stage.

From there...

I looked at the empty chairs spread across the hall.

Tomorrow...

every one of them would be occupied.

Tomorrow...

this hall would witness the beginning of another chapter in someone's life.

I stood there for a long time without speaking.

Not because I was remembering the past.

Because I was grateful to be present.

Life doesn't always give us the endings we imagine.
Sometimes...
it gives us something even better.
The chance to stand beside the people we love...
and sincerely celebrate their happiness.
Looking back now...
I think that was the moment I truly understood what
acceptance meant.
It wasn't pretending that nothing hurt.
It was realising that someone else's happiness could
become your own.
Just then...
I felt someone standing beside me.
It was Lily.
She looked at the empty stage for a few moments
before speaking.
"You've been smiling ever since we came here."
I looked at her.
"Have I?"
She nodded.
"I think..."
she said softly,
"...you're exactly where you're supposed to be."
I didn't answer.
Because she was right.
Years ago...
I thought my place in Aashika's life would be beside
her.
Now...
I realised my place had never changed.
I was still beside her.
Just in a different way.

And somehow...
that was enough.
Far below the stage...
Aashika looked up at us.
She waved enthusiastically.
Without thinking...
both Lily and I waved back together.
She smiled.
Then returned to discussing decorations with her family.
I watched her for a few more seconds.
Not as the girl I once silently loved.
But as someone whose happiness had become one of my favourite prayers.
Absolutely. This scene should be the emotional climax of Book II, but unlike Book I, it should make readers smile with tears, not cry from regret.
The wedding day arrived much sooner than any of us expected.
Before sunrise...
the entire house was already awake.
Lights were switched on in every room.
Relatives moved from one place to another carrying flowers, trays and gift boxes. Someone was searching for jewellery. Someone else was looking for the photographer. Children ran through the hallway without anyone trying to stop them.
It was beautiful chaos.
The kind that only exists during weddings.
I woke up earlier than everyone else.
Not because someone asked me to.
Sleep simply refused to stay.

I walked towards the balcony.
The morning air was cool.
For a few minutes, I stood there quietly, watching the first rays of sunlight slowly spread across the city.
Today...
another chapter of our lives was about to begin.
After getting ready, Lily joined me downstairs.
She was wearing a traditional saree that Auntie had chosen for her a few days earlier.
She looked at herself nervously.
"I hope I'm wearing this properly."
I smiled.
"You've asked me that at least ten times."
"And?"
"You still look beautiful."
She laughed.
"I'll take that as a yes."
When we reached the wedding hall...
it no longer looked like the place we had seen the previous evening.
Fresh jasmine flowers decorated every entrance.
Golden lights reflected softly from every corner.
Traditional music echoed through the hall.
Guests had already begun arriving.
Everyone was smiling.
Everyone was busy.
Yet somehow...
everything felt perfectly organised.
As usual...
I didn't sit down.
There was too much work left.
Someone needed help arranging the welcome gifts.

The photographer wanted family members to gather
for a few pictures.
The caterers needed directions.
Children kept running onto the stage.
For the next two hours...
I hardly realised how quickly time passed.
Lily was no different.
She had somehow become part of the family within a
few days.
She helped Aunty welcome guests.
She carried flower baskets.
She even learnt how to greet elderly relatives properly.
Watching her laugh with everyone made me smile.
She belonged here.
The groom arrived shortly afterwards.
Traditional music became louder.
Relatives gathered near the entrance.
Everyone welcomed him warmly.
I walked forward and greeted him.
We had spoken several times during the preparations.
He was exactly the kind of person I had hoped
Aashika would find.
Kind.
Respectful.
Calm.
Looking at him...
I understood why she had chosen him.
And strangely...
that thought filled me with peace instead of pain.
The wedding rituals began one after another.
Priests chanted softly.
Family members gathered around the stage.

The hall slowly became quieter.
Everyone's attention shifted towards the entrance.
The bride was about to arrive.
The music changed.
A gentle melody filled the hall.
Almost instinctively...
everyone turned towards the entrance.
So did I.
For a brief moment...
everything around me disappeared.
The conversations.
The camera flashes.
The crowd.
The music.
Everything.
She walked slowly towards the stage.
Wearing a beautiful silk saree.
Jewellery reflected the morning light.
Fresh jasmine flowers rested gently in her hair.
But none of those things were what caught my
attention.
I wasn't looking at the bride.
I was looking at the little girl who once waited
excitedly for train journeys to Bangalore.
The teenager who laughed louder than anyone during
our card games.
The girl who cried while telling me about her first
heartbreak.
The friend who had unknowingly become the biggest
chapter of my youth.
Standing before me now...
she wasn't that little girl anymore.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

She was a woman.
Confident.
Peaceful.
Happy.
Looking back now...
I think that smile healed something inside me too.
Without realising it...
I smiled.
Not because I had forgotten what I once felt.
But because...
after everything life had put both of us through...
she had found the happiness she deserved.
And that was enough.
More than enough.
I felt a gentle touch on my hand.
Lily.
She didn't say anything.
She simply held my hand for a moment.
I looked at her.
She smiled softly.
There were no questions in her eyes.
Only understanding.
I smiled back.
Sometimes...
love doesn't need words.
It simply knows when to stay beside you.
The ceremony continued peacefully.
Sacred fire.
Traditional rituals.
Blessings from elders.
Laughter from children.
Tears from parents.

Everything happened exactly the way every family had hoped.

Finally...

the most awaited moment arrived.

The groom tied the sacred thread around Aashika's neck.

The hall immediately filled with applause.

Flowers rained from every direction.

Traditional music echoed louder than before.

Everyone stood up.

Smiling.

Clapping.

Celebrating.

I clapped too.

With all my heart.

Not because I was pretending.

Because I genuinely meant every blessing I silently wished for her.

After the ceremony...

the stage became crowded.

Family photographs began.

Relatives stood in long queues waiting to congratulate the newly married couple.

The photographer seemed determined to capture every possible combination of people.

Eventually...

someone called my name.

"Mithran!"

"Come..."

"It's your turn."

Lily and I walked towards the stage together.

The moment Aashika saw us...

her smile became even wider.

"There you are."

"I've been looking for both of you."

I laughed.

"We've been working all morning."

"I know."

She looked at Lily.

"Thank you."

Lily looked surprised.

"For what?"

"For taking care of him."

Both of them smiled.

Then Aashika looked at me.

"And thank you..."

"For always keeping your promises."

I understood exactly what she meant.

Years ago...

I had promised that no matter where life took us...

I would always be there whenever she truly needed me.

Today...

I had kept that promise.

The photographer interrupted us.

"Everyone look here."

We stood together.

The bride.

The groom.

Lily.

And me.

The camera flashed.

One photograph.

One moment.

Four different lives.
Bound together by memories.
As we stepped down from the stage...
I looked back one last time.
Aashika was laughing at something her sister had said.
The groom was smiling beside her.
Their families surrounded them with happiness.
I quietly folded my hands.
Not as a goodbye.
As a blessing.
Because some people remain part of our prayers...
long after they stop being part of our dreams.
The wedding ended the way every beautiful wedding
should.
With tired smiles.
Countless photographs.
Half-finished conversations.
Children sleeping on their parents' shoulders.
And families promising to meet again soon.
As the wedding hall slowly emptied...
I stood outside for a few moments.
The evening sky had turned orange.
A gentle breeze carried the fragrance of jasmine
flowers that had decorated the entrance since
morning.
The decorations would be removed tomorrow.
The stage would disappear.
The guests would return to their own lives.
But the memories created that day...
would remain forever.
Before leaving...
Aashika walked towards me.

She was no longer surrounded by photographers or relatives.

For the first time that entire day...

it was just the two of us.

Well...

almost.

Lily quietly stayed a few steps away, giving us the space we didn't even have to ask for.

Aashika smiled.

"So..."

"This is goodbye again."

I smiled.

"It never really is."

She nodded.

"I know."

For a few seconds...

both of us simply looked at each other.

Neither of us searched for the perfect words.

Because after so many years...

we had learned that not every silence needed to be filled.

She took a small envelope from the fold of her saree.

"I wanted to give this to you before you left."

I looked at it.

"What is it?"

"You'll see later."

I accepted it without opening it.

"I'll keep it safe."

She smiled.

"I knew you would."

Then she looked towards Lily.

"Can I steal him for one more minute?"

Lily laughed softly.

"You don't even have to ask."

Aashika looked back at me.

"I've been thinking about something."

"Hmm?"

"If we hadn't met all those years ago..."

"I wonder what kind of people we would've become."

I thought about the question for a moment.

Then I smiled.

"I don't know."

"But I know we'd both be different."

She nodded.

"So do I."

She looked down for a moment before speaking again.

"You know..."

"There was a time when I thought I'd lose you."

I understood exactly which time she meant.

June.

That week of silence.

One decision.

Two futures.

"I'm glad I didn't."

she whispered.

I smiled gently.

"So am I."

She laughed softly.

"You still don't say much."

"I've been saying less since eighteen."

"You've always said less."

"And you've always talked enough for both of us."

She laughed.

"I'll take that as a compliment."

"It is."

Another silence.

This one felt peaceful.

The kind of silence that belongs only to people who have already said everything that truly mattered.

Finally...

she stepped forward and hugged me.

It wasn't a hug filled with sadness.

It wasn't a farewell.

It was gratitude.

Years of friendship.

Years of trust.

Years of memories.

Wrapped into one quiet embrace.

As she stepped back...

she smiled.

"Take care of yourself."

"I will."

"And don't skip meals."

I laughed.

"You really think that'll change?"

She looked towards Lily.

"Please make sure he eats."

Lily smiled.

"I've been trying."

The three of us laughed together.

Before walking away...

Aashika turned back one last time.

"Oh..."

"And Mithran?"

"Hmm?"

"I'm really happy."

I looked at her.

"I know."

"I'm happy too."

She smiled.

Then quietly walked back towards her husband, who was waiting near the car.

He opened the door for her.

She got in.

Before the car left...

she looked out of the window and waved.

I raised my hand.

Not to hold on.

Not to say goodbye.

Just to wish her a beautiful life.

The car slowly disappeared into the evening traffic.

I kept looking until it was no longer visible.

Then...

I took a deep breath.

Not because something had ended.

Because something had finally found its place.

That night...

Lily and I sat on the terrace of Uncle's house.

The city looked peaceful beneath the stars.

For a long time...

neither of us spoke.

She gently rested her head on my shoulder.

"I understand now."

she said quietly.

I turned towards her.

"What?"

"Why you always spoke about her with so much respect."

I smiled.

"There was never anything to forgive."

She shook her head.

"I know."

"You didn't lose someone."

You gained a lifetime of memories."

I looked up at the night sky.

"I've always believed..."

"Some people come into our lives to stay."

"And some come into our lives to shape who we become."

"Aashika did both."

Lily slowly took my hand.

"And now?"

she asked.

I looked at her.

A smile appeared on my face.

"Now..."

"I'm ready to write the rest of my story."

She smiled.

"So am I."

A month later...

we returned to Australia.

Life quietly found its rhythm again.

The apartment that had once belonged to a university student slowly became a home for two people.

We worked.

We travelled.

We argued over silly things.

We celebrated birthdays.

Built careers.
Shared responsibilities.
Collected photographs.
Made new memories.
Years passed so naturally that we hardly noticed them.
Then...
one autumn morning...
beneath a sky filled with golden leaves...
Lily became my wife.
As I held her hand during our wedding...
I wasn't thinking about the past.
I wasn't comparing memories.
I wasn't trying to replace anyone.
I was simply grateful...
that life had given me another chance to love.
Not the same way.
But just as sincerely.
Scene 5 – The Wooden Box
Ten years passed more quickly than I ever imagined.
When I was eighteen...
I believed ten years was an eternity.
Now...
at thirty...
it felt like yesterday.
Life had quietly found its rhythm.
Australia had become home.
Lily and I had built a small life together.
Not a perfect one.
No life ever is.
But it was peaceful.
Every morning began with the same routine.
She would wake up before me.

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BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

I would pretend to be asleep for another five minutes.
She knew I was pretending.
I knew she knew.
Yet...
neither of us ever mentioned it.
Some habits become part of a marriage.
The apartment had slowly filled with memories.
Photographs from our travels.
Books collected over the years.
Small souvenirs from different countries.
A tiny indoor plant that Lily insisted could never die.
It somehow survived despite both of us forgetting to
water it more than once.
Life wasn't exciting every day.
It was ordinary.
And somewhere along the way...
I realised ordinary days were the most beautiful ones.

Chapter Thirty-One

The Reunion

Four years had passed.

Four years.

It didn't sound like much when someone said it aloud.

But life had quietly changed in those four years.

The boy who once travelled to Bangalore with nothing but excitement and overthinking had slowly become a man who measured life differently.

Work.

Responsibilities.

Bills.

Weekends.

Video calls with parents.

Anniversaries.

Little traditions with Lily.

Australia no longer felt like a foreign country.

It had become home.

Not because it looked like India.

But because Lily was there.

One evening...

Mithran's phone rang.

The caller ID displayed a familiar name.

Uncle.

He smiled before answering.

"Hello, Uncle."

"Mithran!"

"How are you, da?"

"I'm good."

"How's everyone?"

For the next fifteen minutes...

they spoke exactly the way family members always do.

Health.

Work.

Parents.

Food.

Weather.

Nothing extraordinary.

Yet every conversation somehow felt important.

Before ending the call...

Uncle suddenly remembered something.

"Oh!"

"I almost forgot."

"Our family reunion is next month."

"You and Lily are coming."

Mithran smiled.

"Of course."

"No excuses."

"I already booked your room."

Mithran laughed.

"You booked it before asking?"

"I knew your answer."

After the call ended...

Lily walked into the living room carrying two mugs of hot chocolate.

"So?"

she asked.

"Who was it?"

"Uncle."

"What did he say?"

"We're going to Bangalore next month."

Her face immediately brightened.

"Really?"

"I've missed everyone."

"So have I."

She sat beside him.

"You know..."

she smiled,

"I've been wanting to visit India again."

"I miss Auntie's cooking."

"I miss Uncle's stories."

"I even miss Bangalore traffic."

Mithran laughed.

"You're probably the only foreigner who misses
Bangalore traffic."

She shrugged.

"It reminds me of family."

A month later...

their flight landed in Bangalore.

The airport looked familiar.

The warm air.

The smell of fresh filter coffee.

The constant announcements.

People rushing everywhere.

Nothing had changed.

Yet somehow...

everything had.

Outside the arrival gate...

Uncle waved enthusiastically.

"There they are!"

Auntie hugged Lily before she even greeted Mithran.

"My daughter has become thinner!"

Lily laughed.

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"Aunty...
that's literally what you said last time."
"And I'll keep saying it."
Everyone laughed.
The drive home felt nostalgic.
Every road carried a memory.
Every traffic signal reminded Mithran of another
phase of life.
The mall where they once spent an entire afternoon.
The ice cream shop.
The bus stop.
The street where he had taught Aashika to ride a
scooter.
He looked outside quietly.
Not because he missed those days.
Because he was grateful they had happened.
The house looked exactly the same.
Only a little older.
Just like the people inside it.
The familiar smell greeted him before anyone else did.
Fresh sambar.
Jasmine flowers.
Old wooden furniture.
Home.
As soon as he stepped inside...
he heard a familiar voice from the kitchen.
"Amma..."
"Where did you keep—"
The voice stopped.
Aashika walked into the living room.
For a moment...
both of them simply smiled.

No awkwardness.

No hesitation.

Just years of friendship standing quietly between them.

"It's been a long time."

she said.

"It has."

"You've become older."

Mithran laughed.

"So have you."

She folded her arms dramatically.

"I was expecting a better compliment."

"You look happy."

He corrected himself.

She smiled.

"That's much better."

Just then...

another voice came from behind.

"So..."

"This is the famous Mithran?"

A young man walked into the room.

Calm.

Friendly.

Smiling naturally.

Aashika looked at Mithran.

"This is My husband."

Aashika's Husband extended his hand immediately.

"I've heard way too many stories about you."

Mithran shook his hand.

"I hope only the good ones."

Aashika's Husband laughed.

"Mostly."

"Although..."

"I also heard you once forgot to eat for almost an entire day."

Mithran looked at Aashika.

"You still tell people that?"

She grinned proudly.

"Of course."

"It's an important historical event."

Everyone laughed.

A few moments later...

Lily joined them carrying a tray of juice.

The two women smiled at each other immediately.

"It feels strange."

Lily admitted.

"I've heard so much about you."

Aashika smiled.

"I've heard plenty about you too."

Within minutes...

they were talking as though they had known each other for years.

Recipes.

Australia.

Office stories.

Travel.

Family.

Everything.

Mithran quietly watched them.

Years ago...

he would've never imagined this moment.

The most important girl from his past...

laughing with the woman who became his future.

Not competing.

Not comparing.
Simply...
sharing a conversation.
Life had written something far more beautiful than he
had once expected.
That evening...
all four of them sat together on the terrace.
The Bangalore breeze felt exactly the same.
Tea for everyone.
Fruit juice for Mithran.
Aashika looked at the glass and laughed.
"You still don't drink tea?"
"No."
"Coffee?"
"No."
Arjun looked surprised.
"Then what do you survive on?"
Lily answered before Mithran could.
"Water."
"And mango juice."
Everyone burst into laughter.
For the rest of the evening..
they spoke about everything except the past.
Not because they were avoiding it.
Because they no longer needed to live inside it.
The past had become something they could smile at.
Not something they had to heal from.
As the night grew quieter...
Mithran looked around the terrace.
Lily was laughing at one of Arjun's terrible jokes.
Aashika was teasing both of them.

The city lights stretched endlessly beyond the balcony.
For a brief moment...
he closed his eyes.
Not to remember.
But to thank life.
Some stories don't end with two people holding hands.
Some stories end with four people smiling together.
And somehow...
that felt even more beautiful
The next morning...
Bangalore woke up exactly the way Mithran remembered.
The sound of vegetable vendors echoed through the streets.
Fresh jasmine flowers hung outside small shops.
The smell of hot idlis drifted from nearby restaurants.
Nothing about the city had changed.
Only the people had.
After breakfast...
Uncle looked around the dining table.
"So..."
"Everyone is free today."
Arjun looked up from his coffee.
"I've taken leave."
Aashika nodded.
"So have I."
Lily smiled.
"I've been waiting for this."
Uncle clapped his hands together.
"Good."

"We're all going out."

"Where?"

Mithran asked.

Uncle laughed.

"Everywhere."

That one word somehow made everyone smile.

Some family traditions never changed.

There was never a proper plan.

They simply got into the car...

and decided everything on the way.

By ten in the morning...

the two cars slowly left the house.

Uncle insisted on driving one.

Arjun drove the other.

Mithran sat beside Aashika's Husband.

Behind them...

Aashika and Lily were already talking nonstop.

"What are they discussing?"

Aashika's Husband whispered.

Mithran smiled.

"I have no idea."

"But I know they'll still be talking when we reach."

Arjun laughed.

"I've noticed."

The first stop...

was an old restaurant.

One they had visited years ago.

The signboard had changed.

The paint looked newer.

But the food...

tasted exactly the same.

As everyone waited for breakfast...

Aunty suddenly smiled.

"You know..."

"The last time all of us came here..."

She looked directly at Mithran.

"You ordered the same juice twice."

Mithran laughed.

"I was hungry."

"No."

Aashika interrupted immediately.

"You were confused."

"I wasn't."

"You forgot that you'd already ordered."

"I did not."

"You absolutely did."

Lily looked at Arjun.

"Does this happen often?"

Aashika's Husband nodded dramatically.

"I think we're both married to forgetful people."

Everyone burst into laughter.

Breakfast lasted almost an hour.

Not because anyone ate slowly.

Because every five minutes...

someone remembered another old story.

Every memory somehow became funnier with time.

After breakfast...

they walked around a nearby shopping street.

Nothing special.

Just ordinary shops.

Clothing stores.

Bookstores.

Street vendors.

Toy shops.

Exactly the kind of places families spend entire afternoons without buying much.
Lily suddenly stopped in front of a small handicraft shop.
"So beautiful..."
she whispered.
Inside...
wooden carvings filled every shelf.
Handmade keychains.
Small sculptures.
Decorative boxes.
Everything looked unique.
She carefully picked up a tiny wooden elephant.
"What do you think?"
she asked Mithran.
"I think..."
"You've already decided."
She laughed.
"You know me too well."
Nearby...
Aashika smiled.
"He said the same thing years ago."
Lily looked surprised.
"Really?"
Aashika nodded.
"He always knows when someone has already made up their mind."
Mithran smiled quietly.
Some habits really never changed.
An hour later...
everyone gathered outside an ice cream shop.
Uncle immediately announced,

"No one is allowed to refuse."

Mithran looked at the menu.

"So many flavours..."

Aashika leaned closer.

"You'll still choose mango."

"I might."

"You definitely will."

Five minutes later...

everyone looked at Mithran's cup.

Mango.

Aashika folded her arms proudly.

"I knew it."

Lily laughed.

"I've been trying for years to make him try different flavours."

"And?"

"Nothing."

"He always comes back to mango."

Mithran shrugged.

"When something is already perfect..."

"Why change it?"

Aashika's Husband smiled.

"That's surprisingly philosophical."

The afternoon slowly turned into evening.

The weather became cooler.

Clouds gathered above the city.

Without planning...

they found themselves walking through Cubbon Park.

Families sat on the grass.

Children chased pigeons.

Couples walked quietly beneath old trees.

The entire park felt peaceful.

For a while...
the four of them walked together without speaking.
There was no need.
Some silences exist because everyone feels
comfortable.
Lily suddenly stopped.
"Wait."
"I want one picture."
She handed her phone to Uncle.
"Can you take one?"
The four of them stood together.
Mithran.
Lily.
Aashika.
Aashika's Husband.
Just before the photo was taken...
Aashika laughed.
"Why does this feel like life is showing us how
everything was supposed to happen?"
Nobody answered.
Because...
everyone silently agreed.
The camera clicked.
One photograph.
Four smiling faces.
No regrets.
No hidden pain.
Only gratitude.
As they continued walking...
Mithran quietly looked at the sky.
He remembered another walk.
Years ago.

Just him and Aashika.
Talking about college.
Dreams.
The future.
Back then...
neither of them knew where life would take them.
Now...
they did.
And strangely...
it was beautiful.
Not because they had ended up together.
But because they had never lost the respect they had
for each other.
The sun slowly disappeared behind the trees.
Golden light covered the entire park.
Children laughed in the distance.
Birds returned to their nests.
The evening breeze gently moved through the leaves.
For a brief moment...
everything felt perfectly still.
Life hadn't given them the ending they once
imagined.
It had given them something quieter.
Something deeper.
A life where they could look at each other...
without wondering,
"What if?"
Instead...
they smiled because they could honestly say,
"I'm glad you're happy."
And sometimes...
that is the purest form of love.

Dinner ended much later than anyone expected.
The dining table was still filled with empty plates,
laughter, and unfinished conversations.
Uncle was telling one of his old stories for what was
probably the hundredth time.
Aunt interrupted him every few minutes.
"That didn't happen."
"It happened exactly like that."
"No."
"It didn't."
Lily couldn't stop laughing.
"I've heard this story twice already..."
"And both versions are completely different."
Everyone burst into laughter.
Slowly...
one by one...
everyone disappeared into their rooms.
The house became quiet.
Exactly the kind of quiet that only comes after a day
filled with family.
Mithran stepped onto the terrace.
The cool Bangalore breeze greeted him immediately.
The city looked different at night.
Streetlights stretched endlessly.
Vehicles moved like tiny streams of light.
Somewhere far away...
someone was playing old Tamil songs.
He rested both hands on the terrace wall.
Closed his eyes.
And simply breathed.
"So..."
a familiar voice said behind him.

"Still thinking too much?"

He smiled before turning around.

Aashika.

Holding two bottles of mango juice.

"I knew you'd come here."

she said.

"You always liked terraces."

"And you still remember that?"

"I remember a lot of things."

she smiled.

She handed him one bottle.

"No tea."

"No coffee."

"I know."

He laughed.

"You really do."

For a few minutes...

neither of them spoke.

They simply looked at the city.

"It's strange."

Aashika finally said.

"What is?"

"We spent so much time waiting to grow up."

"And now..."

"We keep talking about school."

Mithran smiled.

"I was thinking the same thing."

She laughed softly.

"Remember lockdown?"

"How could I forget?"

"You used to call me at random times."

"You answered every time."

"You were annoying."

"You still answered."

She smiled.

"I know."

The conversation slowly wandered through time.

Childhood visits.

Summer holidays.

Birthday surprises.

The endless phone calls.

The terrible jokes.

The handmade gifts.

The silly arguments.

Everything.

Suddenly...

she laughed loudly.

"Oh my God..."

"What?"

"The YouKnow cards."

Mithran immediately covered his face.

"Please don't."

"You seriously made an entire card game."

"I was bored."

"No..."

"You were obsessed."

"I was creative."

She laughed even harder.

"No..."

"You were definitely obsessed."

Both of them couldn't stop laughing.

For a moment...

they weren't thirty-one-year-old adults anymore.

They were simply two teenagers again.

"You still have those cards?"

she suddenly asked.

Mithran smiled.

"I do."

"No way."

"I kept one pack."

She shook her head.

"I can't believe you."

"You should've thrown them away years ago."

"Maybe."

"But I didn't."

She smiled.

"I'm glad."

Silence returned.

Not awkward.

Not heavy.

Comfortable.

After a while...

she looked towards the city.

"You know..."

"Hmm?"

"There was one thing I always wanted to tell you."

"What?"

She smiled.

"I never thanked you properly."

"For what?"

"For staying."

Mithran looked at her quietly.

"There were so many moments..."

she continued.

"...when life became confusing."

"My first breakup."

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"College."

"My first job."

"Moving into adulthood."

"You were always there."

"Even when you were thousands of kilometres away."

She looked at him.

"I don't think I ever said thank you."

Mithran smiled gently.

"You never had to."

"No."

"I did."

She looked away for a moment.

"I don't think I'd be the same person today..."

"...if you hadn't been part of my life."

The words stayed between them.

Soft.

Honest.

Enough.

Mithran looked at the city lights.

Then quietly replied,

"I could say exactly the same."

She smiled.

For a while...

they simply stood there.

Neither trying to continue the conversation.

Neither trying to end it.

The wind became slightly stronger.

Somewhere nearby...

the smell of jasmine flowers drifted through the air.

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"If you could go back..."

"...would you change anything?"

He thought for a long time.

Long enough that she wondered if he hadn't heard the question.

Finally...

he smiled.

"Years ago..."

"I would've said yes."

"And now?"

He looked up at the night sky.

"No."

"Because if I changed one thing..."

"I might lose everything that came after it."

She looked at him for several seconds.

Then...

without saying a word...

she smiled.

A smile filled with understanding.

"I think..."

she whispered.

"...that's the most grown-up thing you've ever said."

He laughed.

"It only took me thirteen years."

"So slow."

"I've always been slow."

"I know."

Both of them laughed again.

Downstairs...

Lily called from the balcony.

"Mithran..."

"We're cutting the cake!"

He smiled.

"I'm coming."

Before walking downstairs...

he looked once more at the Bangalore skyline.

Then at Aashika.

"I'm really happy."

he said.

She smiled.

"So am I."

No promises.

No confessions.

No hidden meanings.

Just two people...

who had finally reached a place where happiness no longer depended on what could have been.

As they walked downstairs together...

neither of them realized...

that one conversation still remained.

A conversation that had waited sixteen years.

It would finally find its words...

when they were thirty-four.

Chapter Thirty-Two

Some Promises Never Needed Words

The next morning...
Mithran woke up before everyone else.
It had always been one of his habits.
Even after years...
his body still refused to sleep late.
The house remained silent.
Only the ceiling fan gently hummed above him.
Outside...
the first rays of sunlight slowly coloured the
Bangalore sky.
He quietly walked downstairs.
Careful not to wake anyone.
The front gate creaked softly as he stepped outside.
The morning air felt cooler than Australia.
Different.
Familiar.
Comforting.
He started walking without deciding where to go.
Some roads don't need directions.
Your feet remember them.
The bakery at the corner had already opened.
Fresh bread.
Tea.
The smell of butter.
Exactly the way it had always been.
The old newspaper shop still stood opposite the bus
stop.

The owner looked older.
His hair had turned completely grey.
But he still arranged newspapers in the exact same way.
Some things changed.
Some things simply grew older.
As Mithran continued walking...
he found himself standing near a small park.
One he had visited years ago.
Back then...
he and Aashika had once argued over something completely meaningless.
She wanted to sit under the trees.
He wanted to walk.
Eventually...
they had done both.
He smiled.
Funny...
how the smallest memories survived the longest.
"You still walk without telling anyone?"
A familiar voice came from behind.
Mithran turned around.
Aashika.
Holding two paper cups.
"I guessed you'd be here."
she smiled.
"How?"
"You always disappear in the morning."
She handed him a cup.
"Fruit juice."
He laughed.
"You remembered."

"I remember everything."

They sat on the same bench.

Exactly where they had once sat years ago.

For a few minutes...

neither of them spoke.

The park slowly filled with people.

Children learning to ride bicycles.

Older couples walking hand in hand.

Morning joggers.

Street dogs lazily stretching beneath trees.

Life quietly beginning another day.

"You know..."

Aashika suddenly said.

"When we were younger..."

"I used to think growing up would solve everything."

Mithran smiled.

"And?"

"It only gave us different problems."

He laughed.

"That's true."

"But..."

she continued.

"I think..."

"...it also taught us which problems are worth carrying."

Mithran looked at her.

"I like that."

She smiled.

"I learnt it the hard way."

He nodded.

"So did I."

The silence that followed wasn't empty.

It was filled with understanding.
The kind that only years could create.
Suddenly...
Aashika pointed towards a little boy.
He couldn't have been more than six.
Trying to ride a bicycle.
Every few seconds...
he lost balance.
His father patiently ran behind him.
Never letting him fall completely.
"That's life."
she whispered.
"What do you mean?"
"We think we're riding alone."
"But someone is always running behind us."
"Parents."
"Friends."
"Teachers."
"People we don't even realise are helping us."
Mithran quietly watched the father.
The little boy laughed every time he almost fell.
"I think..."
Mithran replied.
"...sometimes we don't even realise who helped us
until years later."
She smiled.
"Exactly."
For a while...
they simply watched the little boy finally ride without
support.
His father stopped running.
Smiled proudly.

But didn't call him back.
"He let go."
Aashika softly said.
"So the boy could keep moving."
Neither of them realised...
how perfectly that sentence described their own lives.
The sun climbed higher.
People slowly filled the park.
"We should go."
Aashika finally said.
"They'll think we disappeared."
"They probably already do."
Both of them laughed.
As they started walking back...
Mithran looked once behind him.
The same bench.
The same trees.
The same park.
Only two different people sitting there now.
Older.
Calmer.
Grateful.
Life hadn't erased the past.
It had simply taught them how to smile at it.
The first album had already kept everyone busy for
almost an hour.
Yet...
no one wanted to close it.
Every page carried a different version of the same
family.
Children became teenagers.
Teenagers became adults.

Parents slowly grew older.

Grandparents slowly disappeared from the photographs.

Time had quietly arranged itself inside those albums.

Lily gently turned another page.

The transparent plastic sheet made a soft crackling sound.

Underneath...

a slightly faded photograph appeared.

The colours had become dull.

The corners had curled with age.

But the smiles...

were exactly the same.

"Wait..."

Aunty leaned forward.

"Oh..."

"I remember this day."

Everyone instinctively moved closer.

Even Uncle adjusted his spectacles.

"What happened?"

Lily asked.

Aunty laughed.

"That day..."

"These two disappeared."

She pointed at the photograph.

Mithran.

Aashika.

Both couldn't have been older than ten.

"We searched almost the entire park."

Uncle immediately corrected her.

"No."

"We searched the entire zoo."

Aunty rolled her eyes.

"It wasn't a zoo."

"It was the botanical garden."

"No..."

"It was definitely the zoo."

The argument continued.

Exactly the way it always had.

Finally...

Aashika laughed.

"It was the botanical garden."

Uncle sighed dramatically.

"Fine."

"I've lost."

Everyone burst into laughter.

Lily looked back at the photograph.

"What were you both doing?"

Before Mithran could answer...

Aashika answered first.

"He wanted butterflies."

"I wanted ice cream."

"He refused to leave until he caught one."

"I never caught it."

Mithran smiled.

"You never even came close."

she teased.

"I almost did."

"No."

"I definitely almost did."

"You fell into the bushes."

Everyone laughed louder.

Mithran covered his face.

"I knew this story would come."

Lily looked surprised.

"You actually fell?"

"I slipped."

"You rolled."

Aashika corrected.

"It wasn't rolling."

"It absolutely was."

"And then..."

Aunty added while laughing,

"And mud."

"And still..."

Aashika continued,

"...he said..."

She tried to imitate his childhood voice.

"I planned that."

The entire room exploded with laughter.

Even Mithran couldn't stop laughing.

"I seriously said that?"

"You did."

"I was an idiot."

"You were."

Aashika smiled.

"But a funny one."

Silence returned for a moment.

Not because nobody had anything to say.

Because everyone was smiling at the same memory.

Lily looked carefully at the photograph again.

The little boy standing there...

looked completely different from the man sitting
beside her.

Yet...

his eyes hadn't changed.

They still carried the same quiet kindness.

She softly looked at Mithran.

"You really haven't changed much."

He smiled.

"I've changed a lot."

"No."

"You've grown."

"But..."

"...you're still the same person."

Those words stayed in the room.

Softly.

Without demanding attention.

Aashika nodded in agreement.

"That's true."

"He still overthinks."

"He still drinks only juice."

"He still arrives everywhere fifteen minutes early."

"He still apologizes even when it isn't his fault."

"He still smiles instead of arguing."

Lily looked at him.

"She's right."

Mithran laughed.

"I didn't know everyone had been observing me."

"Oh..."

Aashika smiled.

"We've been observing you since you were five."

Everyone laughed again.

Another page turned.

Another memory appeared.

This time...

it was during one of the family trips.

A train journey.

Children leaning outside the window.
Parents shouting at them to come inside.
Plastic lunch boxes.
Steel water bottles.
Everything looked so simple.
Lily couldn't stop looking.
"These pictures feel different."
"What do you mean?"
Uncle asked.
She thought for a moment.
"They don't look perfect."
"They're blurry."
"Some people aren't even looking at the camera."
"But..."
"...they feel real."
Nobody replied immediately.
Because everyone silently understood.
Back then...
people didn't take photographs to impress anyone.
They took them...
because they wanted to remember.
Aashika slowly turned another page.
There...
between dozens of photographs...
was one everyone recognised immediately.
The selfie.
Her sister's wedding.
The same selfie.
The one Mithran had quietly kept all these years.
Lily smiled.
"I've seen this."
Aashika looked surprised.

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"You have?"

Lily nodded.

"It was inside one of his journals."

Mithran looked slightly embarrassed.

"I forgot it was there."

"You never forget anything."

Aashika smiled.

"True."

Lily added.

"He remembers the smallest details."

"The strangest things."

"The exact dates."

"The exact places."

"The exact conversations."

Mithran laughed softly.

"My memory only works for useless things."

"No."

Aashika replied gently.

"It works for important things."

For a brief second...

their eyes met.

Not with sadness.

Not with regret.

Simply with gratitude.

Lily noticed it.

She smiled quietly to herself.

Not once had she felt insecure.

Because she understood something very few people
ever learn.

A person's past is not your competition.

It is simply the road that brought them to you.

She reached for Mithran's hand beneath the table.

Held it gently.
Without saying a word.
He looked at her.
Smiled.
And held it back.
Aashika noticed.
She smiled too.
Not because she felt left behind.
But because she genuinely felt happy.
Looking at the two of them...
she silently thought,
"He's home."
She never said those words aloud.
She didn't need to.
Sometimes...
the happiest blessings remain inside the heart.
Outside...
rain slowly began falling.
Tiny droplets tapped softly against the windows.
The room became even quieter.
Warmer.
More peaceful.
Uncle closed the album.
"Enough for today."
"If we continue..."
"We'll still be sitting here tomorrow."
Nobody disagreed.
Because every photograph had reminded them of one
simple truth.
Life doesn't move away from us.
It carries us forward.
One picture...

One memory...

One chapter at a time.

The rain hadn't stopped.

By the time everyone decided to leave, the roads were shining under the streetlights. Tiny drops continued to fall, creating soft ripples on every puddle they passed.

Uncle looked outside through the front door and sighed.

"Looks like Bangalore doesn't want us to leave."

Aunty smiled as she picked up her shawl.

"It never lets anyone leave easily."

Everyone laughed.

Since two cars had come, they decided to return the same way.

Uncle and Aunty got into the first car.

Aashika's husband offered to drive.

Mithran sat in the front passenger seat.

Behind them...

Lily and Aashika sat together.

The journey began with complete silence.

Not because anyone was uncomfortable.

Because everyone was tired after an entire day of walking, laughing, and remembering.

The sound of rain gently tapping against the windshield became the only conversation for the first few minutes.

The wipers moved rhythmically from one side to the other.

Left...

Right...

Left...

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Right...

Almost like they were keeping time with the quiet evening.

After a while...

Lily leaned slightly toward Aashika.

"I've been meaning to ask you something."

Aashika smiled.

"What?"

"Has he always been this quiet?"

She pointed toward Mithran.

Without even looking up, Aashika answered immediately.

"No."

Mithran turned slightly.

"Oh?"

"No," she repeated with a grin. "He talks a lot."

"I do not."

"You do."

"I don't."

"You just don't talk to everyone."

Lily nodded.

"I've noticed that too."

"He listens more than he speaks."

Aashika smiled as she looked out of the rain-covered window.

"That's always been his biggest strength."

She paused for a moment.

"And sometimes..."

"...his biggest weakness."

Mithran looked back at her.

"What does that mean?"

She smiled.

"You keep too many things inside."
"You think people will understand without you saying anything."
"For years..."
"...I used to think that too."
The car became quiet again.
Her words weren't accusations.
They were observations.
Gentle ones.
Mithran looked outside at the passing lights.
She wasn't wrong.
Lily quietly watched both of them.
There was something beautiful about their friendship.
They didn't complete each other's sentences.
They completed each other's memories.
Not because they had rehearsed them.
Because they had lived them.
After a few minutes...
Aashika suddenly laughed.
"You remember that bus journey?"
Mithran smiled immediately.
"Which one?"
"The one where you almost missed the bus because you were buying chips."
Lily laughed.
"So that story is actually true?"
"It happened once," Mithran defended himself.
"It happened twice," Aashika corrected.
"It definitely happened twice," her husband added, laughing.
Mithran looked surprised.
"You know about that too?"

"I've heard many stories."

"Oh no..."

Mithran covered his face dramatically.

"So you've all had meetings about me?"

"Not meetings," Aashika smiled.

"Stories."

The rain slowly became heavier.

Traffic came to a stop at a long signal.

The red light reflected across the wet road like a ribbon.

Nobody seemed impatient.

Some journeys deserved to be slow.

Lily suddenly asked,

"Can I tell you something?"

Everyone looked back.

"When Mithran first told me about all of you..."

"I thought he was exaggerating."

Aashika smiled.

"About what?"

"About how close this family is."

She looked around the car.

"But now..."

"I think he actually understated it."

Aunty's words from earlier echoed in Mithran's mind.

"You're not a guest here."

He smiled quietly.

Home wasn't always a place.

Sometimes...

it was simply the people who remembered every version of you.

The little boy.

The teenager.

The confused college student.

The overthinking young man.

The husband.

All of them.

The car slowly entered their street.

The familiar gate appeared ahead.

The headlights illuminated the rain-soaked driveway.

As everyone stepped out...

the rain had almost stopped.

The cool breeze carried the smell of wet earth

through the garden.

Lily looked up at the sky.

"I understand now."

"What?" Mithran asked.

She smiled softly.

"Why you always called this place home."

Mithran didn't answer.

He simply looked at the house.

The same walls.

The same balcony.

The same front door.

Years had passed.

Lives had changed.

Dreams had changed.

People had changed.

Yet somehow...

this house still held every version of who they had
once been.

As they walked inside...

Aashika turned back for just a second.

"Mithran."

"Hmm?"

"Tomorrow morning..."

"I want to show you something."

"What is it?"

She smiled mysteriously.

"If I tell you now..."

"...it won't be a surprise."

She walked inside before he could ask another question.

Mithran looked at Lily.

She laughed.

"I think your curiosity is going to keep you awake tonight."

He smiled.

"It probably will."

Little did he know...

tomorrow wouldn't just show him an old place.

It would quietly begin a conversation...

that had been waiting for sixteen years.

Chapter Thirty-Three

The Roads That Remember

The next morning arrived much earlier than anyone expected.

The rain from the previous night had washed the entire city clean. The trees looked greener, the air felt lighter, and even the sunlight seemed softer as it slipped through the curtains.

Mithran woke up to the familiar smell of filter coffee drifting through the house. Somewhere downstairs, Aunty was already busy in the kitchen. The sound of vessels, laughter, and the television playing morning news made the house feel exactly the way it always had.

For a few seconds...

he forgot he was thirty-four.

It felt as though he had gone back to being eighteen again.

After breakfast, everyone settled into their own routines.

Uncle disappeared into the garden to water the plants. Aunty began arranging things in the kitchen. Lily sat on the sofa talking to Aashika's mother, trying to learn a few Tamil words that everyone had been teasing her about.

Mithran was helping Uncle trim a small jasmine plant when he heard footsteps behind him.

"Mithran."

He turned around.

Aashika stood there holding two bike helmets.

One black.

One white.

She tossed the black one towards him.

He caught it instinctively.

"What?"

"Wear it."

He looked confused.

"Why?"

"We're going out."

"Where?"

She smiled.

"I already told you."

"It's a surprise."

He looked towards Lily.

"You knew about this?"

Lily nodded.

"I did."

"And you didn't tell me?"

"I was instructed not to."

She raised both her hands dramatically.

"I'm innocent."

Everyone laughed.

Ten minutes later...

the two of them were riding through the streets of
Bangalore.

Not in a car.

Not with family.

Just the two of them.

Exactly the way they had travelled countless times
during college.

Traffic had already started building.

Office buses filled the roads.

Street vendors arranged fresh flowers outside small shops.

School children hurried across pedestrian crossings, their oversized school bags bouncing with every step.

Life was moving at its usual pace.

Yet...

inside Mithran's heart...

time had slowed down.

Aashika rode confidently through the familiar roads.

She hadn't changed.

She still hummed songs without realising it.

She still stopped at every signal a little too early.

She still muttered complaints whenever someone cut across the lane.

Some habits never leave.

"So..."

Mithran spoke over the sound of the wind.

"Are you planning to tell me where we're going?"

"No."

"Give me one clue."

"No Just one."

"No."

He laughed.

"You've become more stubborn."

"I learnt from you."

"I was never stubborn."

She laughed loudly.

"Should I call Lily and ask?"

"You wouldn't dare."

"I absolutely would."

She shook her head.

"No need."

"We're almost there."

After another fifteen minutes...

the traffic slowly disappeared.

The roads became quieter.

Large apartment buildings gave way to older neighbourhoods.

Small tea stalls stood beneath ancient rain trees.

The streets looked untouched by time.

Something about the place felt strangely familiar.

Mithran looked around carefully.

Then...

his eyes widened.

"No way..."

Aashika smiled without turning back.

"You recognised it?"

"I think so..."

A few more turns later...

the bike came to a gentle stop.

Mithran slowly removed his helmet.

For several seconds...

he simply stared.

In front of him stood an old government park.

The paint on the entrance gate had faded.

The swings had been replaced.

The benches looked newer.

But the enormous banyan tree in the middle still stood exactly where it always had.

He looked towards Aashika.

"You brought me here?"

She nodded.

"You said once..."

"...this was your favourite place in Bangalore."

He smiled softly.

"I completely forgot."

"I didn't."

They walked through the entrance together.

Children ran across the open ground, laughing as they chased one another. A grandfather patiently taught his granddaughter how to fly a small kite. A young couple sat beneath a tree sharing roasted peanuts.

The park was full of strangers.

Yet...

it somehow felt familiar.

Aashika walked ahead confidently.

She didn't need directions.

She remembered every turn.

Every path.

Every corner.

Finally...

she stopped near an old stone bench beneath the banyan tree.

She gently brushed away a few fallen leaves before sitting down.

Mithran looked at the bench for a long moment.

Then laughed.

"I remember this."

"I knew you would."

"This is where you refused to talk to me because I ate your chips."

"They were my favourite."

"You still made me apologise."

"You deserved it."

"I bought you another packet."

"You bought the wrong flavour."

He laughed helplessly.

"I couldn't win with you."

"You never could."

Both of them laughed.

The laughter echoed softly beneath the trees.

For a few moments...

they were no longer adults carrying responsibilities.

They were simply two children remembering the smallest arguments of their childhood.

A cool breeze passed through the park.

Dry leaves drifted slowly onto the pathway.

Neither of them hurried to speak.

The silence felt comfortable.

It always had.

After a long pause...

Aashika looked at the old banyan tree.

"You know..."

"When we were younger..."

"I thought we'd always come back here."

Mithran followed her gaze.

"So did I."

She smiled.

"Life had other plans."

He nodded gently.

"It usually does."

They sat there quietly.

Watching children run through the same paths they had once run through themselves.

Watching parents smile the same way their parents once had.

Watching life repeat itself.

Only with different people.
And somehow...
it felt beautiful.
The breeze continued to move gently through the old
banyan tree.
Dry leaves drifted onto the pathway before the wind
carried them away again.
The park had become busier than before.
Children laughed near the swings.
Parents watched from a distance.
An elderly man sat nearby feeding pieces of biscuit to
a few stray dogs.
Life continued around them...
without caring that two old friends were quietly
revisiting sixteen years of memories.
Neither of them spoke for a while.
It wasn't awkward.
After all these years...
they had learned that silence wasn't the absence of
conversation.
Sometimes...
it was the conversation.
Aashika leaned back against the bench and closed her
eyes for a second.
"You know..."
she said softly,
"...I used to think this park was huge."
Mithran looked around.
"So did I."
She opened one eye and laughed.
"It looks so small now."
"We grew."

"We became taller."

"We became older."

She nodded.

"And our problems became bigger too."

Mithran smiled.

"I miss those days."

"Which ones?"

"The days when losing an ice cream felt like the biggest tragedy in life."

Aashika laughed.

"And when getting scolded by our parents felt like the end of the world."

"Exactly."

She looked toward the playground where a little girl had begun crying after falling from a swing.

Her father immediately rushed over, dusted off her dress and lifted her into his arms.

Within seconds...

she was smiling again.

Aashika quietly watched them.

"When we were children..."

she whispered,

"...someone always came to pick us up."

Mithran followed her gaze.

"But when we grow up..."

he completed,

"...we learn to get up on our own."

She looked at him.

"Yeah."

For a few moments...

both of them watched the little girl return to the swing as though nothing had happened.

Children were amazing that way.

They cried completely.

Then laughed completely.

Adults...

were different.

They smiled while carrying things no one else could see.

A vendor slowly pushed his cart past them.

"Ice cream..."

he called out.

"Vanilla... Chocolate... Mango..."

Aashika immediately looked at Mithran.

He looked back at her.

Without saying anything...

both of them started laughing.

"You remembered?"

he asked.

"I'll never forget."

She stood up.

"Come."

A few minutes later...

both of them stood beside the small cart.

The old man smiled.

"What flavour?"

Before Mithran could answer...

Aashika replied confidently.

"Mango."

The vendor handed one to her.

Then looked at Mithran.

"And for you?"

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He smiled.

"The same."

They walked back to the bench with the ice creams in their hands.

For a while...

they ate in complete silence.

Finally...

Aashika looked at him.

"You still eat too slowly."

"You still finish before everyone else."

She smiled proudly.

"I always win."

"You've been saying that since you were eight."

"Because it's true."

She finished hers first.

Exactly as expected.

Then she looked at Mithran's half-finished ice cream.

"I could still win."

He laughed.

"You haven't changed."

"No."

"I haven't."

A few seconds later...

she gently nudged his shoulder.

"Can I ask you something?"

"Hmm?"

"When did you stop getting angry?"

He looked surprised.

"What do you mean?"

"You used to argue."

"You used to complain."

"You used to overthink everything."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

She paused.

"But now..."

"...you're calm."

Mithran looked at the melting ice cream in his hand.

"I don't know."

"I think..."

"...life teaches you which battles deserve your energy."

She listened carefully.

He continued.

"When we're young..."

"...we want every misunderstanding to be explained."

"...every goodbye to be prevented."

"...every relationship to last forever."

He smiled faintly.

"But life doesn't work that way."

She didn't interrupt.

She simply listened.

Exactly the way he had listened to her countless times.

"I realised something after moving to Australia."
he said quietly.

"You can't control who stays."

"You can't control who leaves."

"You can't even control what tomorrow looks like."

He looked toward the children playing football.

"The only thing you can control..."

"...is the kind of person you choose to become."

Aashika remained silent.

The breeze gently moved a few strands of hair across her face.

She tucked them behind her ear before speaking.

"I think Australia made you wiser."

Mithran laughed.

"No."

"It just gave me enough silence to hear my own thoughts."

She smiled.

"I like this version of you."

He looked at her.

"So do I."

For a second...

their eyes met.

Not as two people wondering what could have been.
But as two people grateful for everything that had been.

A group of school children ran past the bench
laughing loudly.

One little boy accidentally bumped into Mithran.

"I'm sorry, Anna!"

he shouted before running away.

Mithran laughed.

"It's okay."

Aashika watched the children disappear.

Then she smiled to herself.

"You know something?"

"What?"

"I've always trusted one thing."

"What?"

She looked at him.

"No matter where life took us..."

"...you'd always become a good man."

Mithran didn't answer immediately.

He simply looked down at the wooden stick in his hand.

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BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

Those words...
meant more than she could possibly know.
Finally...
he smiled.
"I hope I didn't disappoint you."
She shook her head without hesitation.
"Not even once."
The park slowly became quieter.
The afternoon sun had begun to move west.
Long shadows stretched across the walking path.
People slowly started leaving.
Aashika stood up and dusted the back of her jeans.
"We should go."
Mithran nodded.
As they walked toward the exit...
he turned back one last time.
The old bench remained exactly where it had always
been.
Waiting.
Patiently.
As though it knew...
some friendships never really leave.
They simply return...
older than before.
They didn't leave the park immediately.
Instead...
they walked slowly along the old pathway that circled
the lake.
The afternoon had become quieter.
Most of the children had gone home.
Only a few elderly couples remained, walking hand in
hand beneath the trees.

The breeze carried the smell of wet soil from the previous night's rain.

It reminded Mithran of another time.

Another year.

Another version of himself.

"You've become very quiet."

Aashika smiled as they continued walking.

"I've always been quiet."

She looked at him with disbelief.

"No."

"You became quiet."

"There is a difference."

He laughed softly.

"Maybe."

She looked ahead instead of at him.

"You know..."

"When we were younger..."

"I thought you'd become a teacher."

He looked surprised.

"A teacher?"

She nodded.

"You explained everything."

"Even things nobody asked."

"You'd spend half an hour explaining a movie."

"And another half an hour explaining why your explanation was correct."

He laughed.

"I really did that?"

"You still do."

"What about you?"

he asked.

"What did you think you'd become?"

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BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

She smiled.

"I wanted to become everything."

He laughed.

"That sounds like you."

"One week I wanted to become a doctor."

"The next week..."

"An architect."

"Then a pilot."

"Then a photographer."

"I even wanted to become a chef."

"You couldn't even make tea."

"I still can't."

Both of them laughed together.

They reached the small bridge that crossed the lake.

Neither of them walked across immediately.

Instead...

they rested their arms on the railing.

Watching the water move gently beneath them.

"I used to throw stones here."

Mithran said.

"I remember."

"You used to count how many times they skipped."

"You always cheated."

"I never cheated."

"You threw another stone when nobody was looking."

"I was improving my score."

"You were cheating."

He laughed and shook his head.

Silence returned once more.

This time...

it lasted longer.

Aashika watched the ripples on the lake.

"You know something?"

"Hmm?"

"There was a time..."

"...when I thought we'd stop talking forever."

Mithran knew exactly what she meant.

He didn't ask.

He simply nodded.

"I'm glad we didn't."

she said quietly.

"So am I."

She smiled.

"Life would've been very different."

"It would've."

She picked up a small pebble from the bridge.

Rolled it between her fingers.

Then gently dropped it into the lake.

Small circles spread across the surface.

One after another.

Growing wider.

Until they disappeared.

"I've been thinking about something recently."

she said.

"What?"

"Do you think..."

"...people come into our lives for a reason?"

Mithran didn't answer immediately.

He watched the ripples disappear before speaking.

"I think..."

"...some do."

"And some?"

"Some become the reason."

She looked at him.

"What does that mean?"

He smiled.

"I don't think we realise how much one person changes us."

"They don't have to stay forever."

"They don't even have to know."

"But years later..."

"...you suddenly notice..."

"...you make decisions because of something they once taught you."

"You smile because of a memory they gave you."

"You become kinder..."

"...because they were kind to you."

Aashika listened without interrupting.

"Australia taught me many things."

he continued.

"But..."

"I think the people we meet..."

"...teach us even more."

She slowly nodded.

"I agree."

"I learnt patience from Amma."

"Responsibility from Appa."

"Courage from my sister."

She paused.

Then smiled.

"And overthinking..."

"...from you."

Mithran laughed so loudly that a few birds flew from the nearby tree.

"I knew that was coming."

"It had to."

"You've infected everyone."

"I apologise."

"No."

She smiled warmly.

"I think..."

"...you also taught me something."

He looked at her curiously.

"What?"

She thought for a moment before answering.

"You taught me..."

"...how to listen."

"I used to interrupt everyone."

"I used to think my opinion was always correct."

"But after spending years talking to you..."

"I realised..."

"...sometimes people don't need advice."

"They just need someone willing to listen."

Mithran didn't know what to say.

Those words...

meant more than any compliment he had ever received.

He smiled quietly.

"I never knew that."

"Of course you didn't."

"You never notice the good things you do."

The wind became slightly stronger.

Leaves drifted across the bridge.

Some landed on the water.

Others continued floating through the air.

Aashika checked the time.

"We should probably head back."

"They'll think we got lost again."

Mithran laughed.

"That wouldn't be the first time."

"No."

She smiled.

"But hopefully..."

"...the last."

As they walked back toward the parking area...

neither of them realised...

that this ordinary afternoon...

would soon become one of the most unforgettable
memories of their lives.

Because tomorrow...

for the very first time...

Mithran would tell her the one story...

she had never heard.

Not to change the past.

Not to change the future.

But simply because...

some truths deserve peace before they become
memories

Chapter Thirty-Four

The Truth I Never Needed You To Know

The drive back from the park was much quieter than the journey there.

Not because either of them had run out of things to say.

Some conversations leave behind a comfortable silence.

This was one of them.

The city slowly returned around them.

Traffic became heavier.

People hurried home after work.

Shops switched on their evening lights one by one.

Life continued exactly as it always had.

Yet...

something inside Mithran felt unusually peaceful.

After reaching home...

everyone was already waiting for them.

Lily was sitting in the living room with Aunt, trying to learn how to fold jasmine flowers into a garland.

The result...

wasn't very successful.

The flowers kept falling apart.

Aunt laughed every time Lily tried again.

"No..."

"Like this."

She demonstrated once more.

Lily watched carefully.
Then tried again.
This time...
the flowers stayed together.
"I did it!"
she said excitedly.
Everyone clapped.
Even Uncle looked up from his newspaper.
"Very good."
"You've officially become part of the family."
Lily laughed.
"I've been promoted."
Mithran quietly sat beside Uncle.
"Where did you both disappear?"
Uncle asked without looking away from the newspaper.
"The park."
"Oh."
He smiled.
"I guessed."
"You knew?"
"You both always end up there."
Mithran looked surprised.
"Every single visit."
Uncle folded the newspaper and looked at him.
"Some places become habits."
"You don't choose them anymore."
"They choose you."
That sentence stayed with Mithran.
Some places choose you.
Maybe...
people did too.

The evening slowly settled into its usual rhythm.
Aunty called everyone for tea.
As expected...
Mithran received fruit juice instead.
Lily looked at the glass and laughed.
"I still can't believe this."
"What?"
"You've survived thirty-four years without tea."
"I've survived happily."
Aashika joined the conversation.
"He even refuses coffee."
Lily shook her head dramatically.
"I married a very unusual man."
"You did."
Aashika agreed immediately.
Both of them laughed together.
Mithran sighed.
"I don't like the fact that you've become friends."
"We're not friends."
Lily replied.
"We're teammates."
"Against you."
Everyone burst into laughter.
Dinner was unusually lively.
Old stories returned.
New stories were created.
Nobody looked at their phones.
Nobody hurried to leave the table.
Some meals become memorable not because of the food...
but because everyone stays a little longer than necessary.

Later that night...
the electricity suddenly went off.
The entire house became dark.
Only the sound of rain could be heard outside.
"Oh no..."
Aunty sighed.
"Power cut."
"Perfect."
Uncle smiled.
"Now nobody can escape."
Within a few minutes...
candles were placed around the living room.
Soft yellow light filled the house.
The walls danced with moving shadows.
The atmosphere somehow became warmer.
More intimate.
Lily looked around with a smile.
"This is beautiful."
"It happens every rainy season."
Aashika replied.
"I'm actually glad."
Lily admitted.
"We never experience things like this in Australia."
For almost an hour...
everyone simply talked.
No television.
No phones.
No distractions.
Just conversations.
Exactly the way families once spent their evenings.
Uncle began telling stories from his college days.
Aunty interrupted every few minutes.

"That's not how it happened."

"It happened exactly like that."

"No."

"You're exaggerating."

"I never exaggerate."

Everyone laughed.

After Uncle finished...

Aunty looked at Mithran.

"Your turn."

"My turn?"

"Tell Lily one of your embarrassing stories."

"I don't think that's necessary."

"Oh..."

Aashika smiled.

"I know one."

Mithran immediately looked worried.

"Please don't."

She ignored him completely.

"During lockdown..."

she began,

"...he once stayed awake until three in the morning
trying to fix his laptop."

"It wouldn't start."

"He tried everything."

"Then?"

Lily asked.

"He forgot to charge it."

The room exploded with laughter.

"I was tired."

Mithran defended himself.

"You were overthinking."

Aashika corrected.

"Everything."

Lily laughed so hard that tears formed in her eyes.

"I've heard so much about your overthinking."

"I didn't realise it was this bad."

"It was worse."

Aashika replied.

"He once imagined an entire argument..."

"...that never even happened."

Mithran looked down and smiled.

She wasn't wrong.

Back then...

his mind had created storms out of silence.

Now...

he could smile about them.

After a while...

the conversation slowly became quieter.

One by one...

everyone started feeling sleepy.

Uncle stretched.

"I think I'm going to bed."

"So am I."

Aunty agreed.

Within a few minutes...

the living room became almost empty.

Only four people remained.

Mithran.

Lily.

Aashika.

And her husband.

He stood up.

"I'm going to check on something upstairs."

He smiled at the three of them.

"I'll be back."

Aashika nodded.

"Okay."

For a few moments...

none of them spoke.

The rain outside had become lighter.

The candles continued burning quietly.

Then Lily stood up.

"I'll help Aunty in the kitchen."

"You don't have to."

"I know."

She smiled.

"But I want to."

Before leaving...

she looked at Mithran.

Then at Aashika.

She smiled knowingly.

"I'll be back."

The kitchen door slowly closed behind her.

For the first time that evening...

Mithran and Aashika were alone.

Not because anyone planned it.

It simply happened.

Outside...

the rain finally stopped.

Inside...

the candles continued burning silently.

Neither of them knew it yet...

but this quiet evening...

would become the conversation they would both
remember for the rest of their lives.

For a long moment...

neither of them spoke.

The candle on the table flickered gently as the wind slipped through the half-open window.

Outside...

the rain had almost stopped.

Only a few drops continued falling from the roof.

The entire house had become unusually quiet.

From upstairs...

they could hear Uncle laughing at something on television.

Somewhere in the kitchen...

Lily and Auntie were still talking.

Everything felt peaceful.

Aashika leaned back on the sofa.

"You've changed."

She said it casually.

Almost absent-mindedly.

Mithran smiled.

"I hope that's a good thing."

"It is."

She looked at him for a moment before continuing.

"You smile differently now."

"Differently?"

"Yeah."

She searched for the right words.

"When we were younger..."

"...your smile always looked like it was hiding something."

"And now?"

"Now..."

She smiled softly.

"...it looks peaceful."

Mithran looked down at his hands.

"I think peace comes with time."

"No."

She shook her head gently.

"It comes after acceptance."

Those words stayed between them.

Neither of them hurried to break the silence.

After a while...

Aashika looked toward the rain outside.

"Can I ask you something?"

"You've never needed permission."

She laughed.

"True."

She became serious again.

"Have you ever regretted anything?"

Mithran didn't answer immediately.

Instead...

he looked at the candle.

Watching the flame move gently with the breeze.

"I used to think I had many regrets."

he said quietly.

"But now..."

"I think I only had lessons."

She nodded slowly.

"I like that answer."

"What about you?"

he asked.

She smiled.

"I regret hurting a few people without realizing it."

"You never intentionally hurt anyone."

"I know."

She replied softly.

"But sometimes..."

"...not knowing still hurts someone."

Mithran looked at her.

There was honesty in her voice.

The kind that only came with age.

She suddenly laughed.

"You know..."

"I've always wondered something."

"What?"

She looked directly at him.

"Why did you never fall in love?"

For the first time that evening...

Mithran froze.

He looked away.

Not because he was uncomfortable.

Because he had never expected that question.

Aashika noticed.

She smiled.

"See?"

"You're thinking too much already."

He laughed softly.

"Old habits."

"So?"

She folded her hands.

"I'm waiting."

He remained quiet.

Long enough for her smile to slowly disappear.

"Mithran?"

"Hmm?"

"You never answered."

He took a slow breath.

"There was someone."

Aashika smiled immediately.

"I knew it."

"I always knew there was someone."

"You hid it very well."

"I wasn't hiding."

"No?"

She teased.

"Then who was she?"

Mithran looked outside the window again.

The streetlights reflected softly on the wet road.

"I met her..."

"...when I was very young."

Aashika smiled.

"School?"

He nodded.

"We grew up together."

"We fought."

"We laughed."

"We travelled."

"We became friends."

"The kind of friends..."

"...people assume will always remain friends."

Aashika listened quietly.

Without interrupting.

"I never planned to love her."

"It simply happened."

"So slowly..."

"...that even I didn't notice."

The room became silent.

Aashika's smile slowly faded.

Not because she understood.

Because she was beginning to.

Mithran continued looking outside.

"I never told anyone."

"Not my parents."

"Not my friends."

"Not even myself."

"I kept telling myself..."

"...it was just friendship."

"Until one day..."

"...I realised..."

"...I was already too late."

Aashika lowered her eyes.

Her heartbeat had quietly become faster.

She didn't know why.

Or perhaps...

she already did.

Mithran smiled faintly.

"The funny thing is..."

"I was never sad because she didn't love me."

"I was sad..."

"...because I never wanted my feelings to become a burden for her."

"So..."

"I chose silence."

"I thought..."

"If she never knows..."

"...she'll never have to choose between her happiness..."

"...and mine."

Aashika slowly looked at him.

Her eyes no longer carried curiosity.

Only emotion.

"Mithran..."

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she whispered.
He finally looked at her.
For the first time since the conversation had begun.
His smile was peaceful.
Not broken.
Not hopeful.
Just...
peaceful.
"I loved someone once."
he said softly.
"And letting her be happy..."
"...became the greatest way I knew how to love."
Aashika couldn't speak.
Not yet.
Somewhere deep inside her...
pieces of old memories had quietly begun fitting
together.
The midnight birthday wishes.
The long phone calls.
The handmade gifts.
The way he always listened.
The way he always stayed.
The way he quietly disappeared whenever she was
happy.
Everything.
For the first time in her life...
she wasn't remembering individual moments.
She was seeing the whole story.
The story she had unknowingly lived.
She slowly whispered...
Almost afraid of the answer.
"...Who was she?"

Mithran looked at her.

The candlelight reflected softly in his eyes.

A gentle smile appeared on his face.

Not the smile of a man confessing.

The smile of a man finally putting down something
he had carried with love.

He took a slow breath.

"...I'll tell you."

"...But first..."

"...I want you to promise me something."

She nodded without hesitation.

"Anything."

He smiled.

"After I tell you..."

"...nothing changes."

"...Not your happiness."

"...Not your marriage."

"...Not our friendship."

"...Promise me..."

"...you'll only listen."

Tears had already begun gathering in Aashika's eyes.

She didn't know why.

She simply nodded.

"I promise."

The room became silent again.

Not the uncomfortable silence they had once
experienced years ago.

This one felt different.

Peaceful.

Honest.

Necessary.

The candle between them continued burning quietly.

Its flame moved gently every time the wind entered through the window.

Outside...

the rain had finally stopped.

Aashika looked at Mithran.

Her eyes were already filled with questions.

But she didn't ask any of them.

She had promised.

She would simply listen.

Mithran smiled softly.

"You know..."

he began,

"...there was a time when I thought I'd never tell anyone this."

He paused.

"I thought..."

"...I'd carry it until the end of my life."

He looked around the living room.

The same walls.

The same family photographs.

The same house where thousands of ordinary moments had quietly become unforgettable memories.

"But life has a strange way of teaching us."

he continued.

"It teaches us that some truths aren't meant to change people."

"They're only meant to set our own heart free."

Aashika remained still.

Not because she wasn't emotional.

Because she didn't want to interrupt even a single word.

Mithran smiled.

"Do you remember your birthday during lockdown?"

She nodded immediately.

"The first one?"

"Yes."

"I stayed awake almost the entire night."

he said with a small laugh.

"I kept checking the time every few minutes."

"I didn't want anyone else to wish you before I did."

Aashika smiled through her tears.

"I remember."

"You were the first."

"I celebrated."

he continued.

"As though..."

"...it was my own birthday."

He laughed quietly at himself.

"I never understood why."

"At least..."

"...not back then."

Aashika slowly lowered her eyes.

"And those handmade gifts..."

he smiled.

"I spent weeks making them."

"Half of them looked terrible."

She laughed despite the tears.

"They didn't."

"They were beautiful."

"I made them because..."

He paused.

"...seeing you smile somehow made my entire week better."

Another silence.

Longer than before.

"I never expected anything in return."

he continued.

"I never made those gifts hoping you'd love me."

"I made them because..."

"...you mattered."

He looked toward the family photographs hanging on the wall.

"When you told me about your first heartbreak..."

he said softly,

"...I remember sitting alone after the call."

"I wasn't sad because someone else existed."

"I was sad..."

"...because you were crying."

"I wished..."

"...whoever came into your life..."

"...would never make you cry again."

Aashika pressed her lips together.

The tears that had gathered in her eyes slowly rolled down her cheeks.

She didn't wipe them away.

Mithran noticed.

He smiled gently.

"Don't cry."

"You promised."

"I'm not telling you this..."

"...to make you feel guilty."

"I'm telling you..."

"...because guilt is the last thing I ever wanted you to carry."

She nodded silently.

Trying to stop the tears.

Unable to.

"I remember June."

he whispered.

"The misunderstanding."

"The silence."

"The messages."

"I thought..."

"...I had lost the most important friend in my life."

"I wasn't scared of losing someone I loved."

"I was scared..."

"...of losing you.

The room felt heavier now.

Not because of sadness.

Because of honesty."

"I left for Australia."

he continued.

"I carried many memories with me."

"Some happy."

"Some painful."

"But something changed there."

"I finally understood..."

"...that loving someone..."

"...and expecting them to belong to you..."

"...are two completely different things."

He smiled.

"And I chose the first one."

Aashika slowly looked at him.

Her eyes were red.

She had never seen him speak this much.

Not once.

Not in all the years she had known him.

He laughed softly.

"I know."

"I talk too much now."

She smiled through her tears.

"I should've made you speak earlier."

"You tried."

he replied.

"I was just afraid."

"Afraid of what?"

she whispered.

"That one sentence..."

he smiled,

"...might change everything."

He looked directly into her eyes.

For the first time.

There was no hesitation.

No fear.

No hope.

Only peace.

"So..."

he said quietly,

"...the girl I told you about..."

"...the one I grew up with..."

"...the one who unknowingly became the first person

I ever loved..."

"...was you."

Silence.

No dramatic music.

No shock.

No disbelief.

Only silence.

Because somewhere deep inside...

Aashika had already known.
Not consciously.
But her heart had quietly understood long before her
mind did.
She closed her eyes.
Every memory suddenly returned.
The birthday wishes.
The gifts.
The train journeys.
The lockdown calls.
The way he always listened.
The way he always remembered everything.
The June misunderstanding.
The quiet goodbye.
The journals.
Everything.
When she finally opened her eyes...
she wasn't looking at the boy who had loved her.
She was looking at the man...
who had loved her enough...
to let her go.
"Mithran..."
Her voice trembled.
"I'm..."
He gently shook his head.
Immediately.
Before she could finish.
"No."
He smiled.
"Don't."
"If the next word is 'sorry'..."
"...please don't say it."

"You never did anything wrong."

"You never made me believe something that wasn't true."

"You never promised me a future."

"You never asked me to wait."

"You were simply..."

He smiled.

"...you."

"And that was enough."

Aashika couldn't stop crying.

"I never knew."

she whispered.

"I know."

he replied.

"That was the plan."

A small laugh escaped through her tears.

"You idiot."

"I know."

"You should've told me."

He smiled.

"No."

"If I had told you..."

"...you would've started thinking about me."

"...instead of yourself."

"And I never wanted that."

"I wanted you to choose your life..."

"...without carrying my feelings."

"You deserved that freedom."

She looked at him for a long time.

Then quietly asked,

"Were you ever angry with me?"

He thought for a moment.

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BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

"No."

"Not even once."

"I was only angry..."

He laughed softly.

"...at my own expectations."

"And one day..."

"...I stopped expecting."

"I simply started praying."

"For what?"

she whispered.

He smiled.

The calmest smile she had ever seen.

"That whoever held your hand one day..."

"...would never let you cry alone."

Another tear rolled down Aashika's cheek.

She slowly reached forward.

Held his hand.

Exactly the way a best friend would.

Nothing more.

Nothing less.

"Thank you."

she whispered.

"For loving me..."

"...without ever asking me to love you back."

Mithran smiled.

"No..."

"Thank you."

"For teaching me..."

"...what love actually feels like."

The candle quietly continued burning.

Outside...

the clouds slowly moved away.

For the first time in sixteen years...
there were no more unsaid words between them.
Only gratitude.
Only peace.
Only two childhood friends...
finally understanding the story they had unknowingly
written together.
Neither of them spoke.
The words had finally been said.
The truth that had lived quietly between them for
almost sixteen years no longer belonged to silence.
It belonged to the past.
The candle continued burning on the table.
Its light danced gently across the room.
Outside...
the rain had stopped completely.
Only the sound of water dripping from the roof
remained.
Aashika still hadn't let go of his hand.
Not because she wanted to hold on.
Because she didn't know how to respond.
No book...
No movie...
No story had ever prepared her for this moment.
She looked at him for a long time.
The same eyes.
The same quiet smile.
The same person who had always stood beside her.
Only now...
she understood him differently.
"So..."
she whispered.

"...every birthday..."

"...every gift..."

"...every train journey..."

"...every late-night call..."

"...you carried all of that alone?"

Mithran smiled gently.

"I never felt alone."

She looked confused.

"Because..."

he continued,

"...every memory I made with you..."

"...was already enough."

Aashika lowered her head.

A tear slipped onto her hand.

She wiped it away immediately.

"I keep thinking..."

she said softly,

"...whether I missed something."

"You didn't."

Mithran answered immediately.

"You never missed anything."

"I hid it."

"I became very good at hiding it."

She gave a weak smile.

"You were."

"I never even imagined..."

"I know."

he interrupted gently.

"And that's exactly why I never told you."

He leaned back against the sofa.

For the first time since the conversation had begun...

he looked completely relaxed.

As though years of weight had quietly disappeared from his shoulders.

"You know what surprised me the most?"

he asked.

"What?"

"I thought telling you would hurt."

"But..."

He smiled.

"...it doesn't."

"It feels..."

He searched for the right word.

"...peaceful."

Aashika looked at him carefully.

She could see it.

There wasn't even a trace of pain in his face.

Only relief.

"You've really moved on..."

she whispered.

Mithran smiled.

"I don't like that phrase."

"Why?"

"Because moving on sounds like forgetting."

"I never forgot."

"I simply..."

"...moved forward."

She slowly nodded.

"That's different."

"It is."

A few seconds passed.

Then...

Aashika laughed unexpectedly.

"What?"

Mithran asked.

"I suddenly remembered something."

"What?"

"The YouKnow cards."

He laughed immediately.

"I completely forgot about those."

"No, you didn't."

"I actually did."

"You wrote one question..."

She tried to remember.

"What's one thing you'll never tell anyone?"

Mithran laughed.

"I remember now."

"You never answered it."

"I couldn't."

"You changed the topic."

"I definitely did."

"And I thought..."

She smiled.

"...you were just being mysterious."

He shook his head.

"I was terrified."

Both of them laughed.

The laughter felt lighter than before.

As though the conversation had quietly healed something inside both of them.

After a while...

Aashika became serious again.

"Mithran..."

"Hmm?"

"I want to tell you something too."

He looked at her.

"I don't know..."
she said slowly,
"...whether I would've loved you the same way."
She paused.
Choosing every word carefully.
"And I don't want to lie to you."
He nodded.
"But..."
"If I had known..."
"...I would've hugged you much tighter."
"...I would've thanked you much earlier."
"...and I would've made sure..."
"...you never cried alone."
Mithran smiled.
Not sadly.
Not happily.
Just...
gratefully.
"I know."
"How?"
"Because that's the kind of person you are."
She looked away.
Fresh tears appeared again.
"You always believed in me..."
she whispered.
"Even when I didn't."
"You always celebrated my happiness..."
"...even when life wasn't giving you what you wanted."
She looked back at him.
"I don't know if I deserve that kind of love."
Mithran immediately shook his head.

"Don't say that."

"You didn't earn it."

"You didn't ask for it."

"You don't have to deserve it."

"Love isn't a reward."

"It's simply..."

"...something we give."

She stared at him.

"Australia really changed you."

He smiled.

"No."

"You did."

Silence.

Not the painful silence from years ago.

Not the awkward silence after misunderstandings.

This silence felt complete.

Aashika slowly stood up.

Walked toward the window.

Looked outside.

The clouds had disappeared.

Above the city...

a few stars had started appearing.

Without turning around...

she spoke softly.

"Thank you..."

"For not letting our friendship become another unfinished story."

Mithran stood beside her.

Keeping a respectful distance.

He looked at the same sky.

"I never wanted to lose my best friend."

"And I never did."

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BOOK TWO • ONLY IF IT WAITS

She smiled.
"No."
"You didn't."
For a long time...
they simply stood there.
Looking at the stars.
Two childhood friends.
No secrets left.
No expectations left.
Only gratitude.
Just then...
they heard footsteps coming from the kitchen.
Lily's voice echoed through the hallway.
"Mithran..."
"Where are you?"
He smiled.
"I'm here."
He looked once more at Aashika.
She smiled back.
A smile that no longer carried questions.
Only understanding.
Without saying another word...
both of them walked back toward the living room.
Not as two people saying goodbye.
But as two friends...
who had finally finished the conversation life had
interrupted sixteen years ago.

Chapter Thirty-Five

Thank You For Existing

The next morning...
the house woke up exactly the way it always did.
The smell of freshly brewed filter coffee drifted
through the kitchen.
Someone had already switched on the television.
A devotional song played softly in the background.
Uncle sat in his usual chair with the newspaper spread
across his lap, occasionally adjusting his glasses as he
read the headlines.
Nothing looked different.
Yet...
everything felt different.
Mithran walked downstairs wearing a simple grey T-
shirt and track pants.
For the first time in years...
his heart felt unusually light.
Not because life had suddenly become perfect.
But because there was nothing left hidden inside it.
"Good morning."
Auntie smiled as she placed breakfast on the table.
"You woke up early today."
"I couldn't sleep much."
She looked at him carefully.
"Were you thinking too much again?"
Before Mithran could answer...
Aashika walked into the dining room.
She smiled.

"He wasn't overthinking."

"He was finally sleeping peacefully."

Mithran looked at her.

For a brief moment...

they simply smiled.

Nothing more.

Nothing less.

No one else understood why.

Only the two of them knew.

Some conversations don't change relationships.

They simply remove the distance that silence created.

Lily walked in a few moments later, still trying to tie her hair into a ponytail.

She looked at everyone gathered around the dining table and laughed.

"I've realised something."

Everyone looked at her.

"In this house..."

"...nobody waits for me before starting breakfast."

Uncle folded his newspaper immediately.

"We were waiting."

"No."

She pointed at Mithran's plate.

"He has already started."

Mithran smiled innocently.

"I was hungry."

"You always are."

Lily replied.

Aashika laughed.

"See?"

"I told you."

"He still forgets everything..."

"...except food."

"I definitely don't forget food."

Mithran defended himself.

Everyone laughed.

Breakfast continued with the usual conversations.

Uncle discussed politics.

Aunty complained that nobody helped her enough in the kitchen.

Lily kept asking for the Tamil names of different dishes.

Every answer made her pronunciation even worse.

"Say it again."

Aunty smiled.

"It's sambar."

"Shaam-bar?"

"No..."

"Sam-bar."

"Sambaar?"

"Close enough."

The entire table burst into laughter.

For the first time...

Mithran wasn't watching the people around him because he was afraid of losing them.

He was simply enjoying them.

Exactly as they were.

After breakfast...

everyone slowly dispersed.

Uncle returned to the garden.

Aunty began clearing the table.

Lily offered to help.

This time...

Aunty didn't refuse.

"You wash."

"I'll dry."

"Deal."

Lily smiled.

Mithran stepped outside into the small garden.

The rain from the previous night still clung to the leaves.

Tiny drops reflected the morning sunlight like little pieces of glass.

He bent down and gently touched one of the jasmine flowers.

Its fragrance immediately reminded him of countless evenings spent in this very house.

"You always come here when you're thinking."

A familiar voice came from behind.

He turned.

It was Aashika.

Holding two cups of fresh orange juice.

"Still no tea."

She smiled.

"Never."

She handed one cup to him.

Then both of them slowly walked toward the old wooden swing in the corner of the garden.

For a while...

they simply watched the trees move gently in the morning breeze.

Birds hopped from branch to branch.

Somewhere nearby...

a pressure cooker whistled.

A milkman's bicycle bell echoed from the next street.

The neighbourhood had already begun another ordinary day.

"You know..."

Aashika said quietly.

"I didn't sleep much either."

Mithran looked at her.

"Were you overthinking?"

She laughed softly.

"For once..."

"...I think I was remembering."

She looked down at the glass in her hand.

"I kept replaying our entire childhood."

"Our school holidays."

"The lockdown."

"The late-night birthday calls."

"The silly arguments."

"The handmade gifts."

"The train journeys."

"The park."

"Everything."

She smiled faintly.

"It's strange."

"What is?"

"I lived those memories..."

"...but I never understood them the way I do now."

Mithran nodded.

"Sometimes..."

"...understanding arrives years after the memory."

She looked at him.

"I think that's true."

Another comfortable silence settled between them.

Not because they had nothing to say.

Because they no longer felt the need to rush their words.

Finally...

Aashika looked toward the morning sky.

"I'm happy."

Mithran smiled.

"I know."

"No..."

She shook her head gently.

"I'm happy..."

"...that the last thing between us wasn't silence."

He looked at her for a long moment.

Then smiled.

"So am I."

She slowly raised her glass.

"A toast?"

He laughed.

"With orange juice?"

"Why not?"

He gently touched his glass against hers.

The soft sound echoed through the quiet garden.

"To childhood."

She smiled.

"To friendship."

He replied.

She nodded.

"And..."

She paused for a moment.

"...to the life we both found."

Mithran smiled.

"No..."

"...to the life we both chose."

Their glasses touched once again.
Neither of them realised...
that this simple morning...
would quietly become one of the most precious
memories they would ever carry.
The rest of the morning passed quietly.
After breakfast...
everyone settled into their own little routines.
Uncle was trimming the rose plants in the garden.
Aunty and Lily disappeared into the kitchen, trying to
prepare lunch together.
From inside, laughter echoed every few minutes.
Sometimes because Lily mispronounced a Tamil
word.
Sometimes because she added the wrong ingredient.
Sometimes...
for no reason at all.
The house felt alive.
Mithran stood near the balcony, looking down at the
street below.
Children were playing cricket exactly the way he and
his cousins once had.
Every now and then, the tennis ball rolled into
someone's gate, followed by loud apologies and even
louder laughter.
Some things never changed.
They simply found new people to continue them.
"You've been standing here for ten minutes."
Aashika walked towards him with two small cups of
ice cream in her hands.
"I thought orange juice was enough."
Mithran smiled.

"It was."

"Then this is dessert."

She handed him one of the cups.

"Mango."

He looked at her and laughed.

"You really don't forget anything."

She shrugged.

"I've had years of practice."

They walked out onto the terrace.

The clouds had finally cleared, leaving behind a bright blue sky.

The breeze was gentle.

The city looked unusually calm.

For a while...

they simply stood there, enjoying the silence.

Aashika opened her ice cream first.

"You know..."

"I think this is the only flavour we've been eating since childhood."

Mithran laughed.

"We've never really experimented."

"No."

"We're too loyal."

They both smiled.

After a few moments...

Aashika looked at him.

"Can I ask you one last question?"

He nodded.

"Of course."

She thought for a moment before speaking.

"If you could go back..."

"...to when we were eighteen..."

"...would you change anything?"

The question stayed in the air.

Mithran didn't answer immediately.

He looked at the neighbourhood below.

The same roads.

The same trees.

The same rooftops that had watched them grow up.

Finally...

he smiled.

"When I was younger..."

"...my answer would've been yes."

"And now?"

"Now..."

He shook his head gently.

"I wouldn't change a single thing."

She looked surprised.

"Not even the painful parts?"

He smiled.

"Especially the painful parts."

"Why?"

"Because they taught me things happiness never could."

He looked at her.

"If I removed every difficult moment..."

"...I wouldn't become the person I am today."

"The misunderstandings."

"The distance."

"The silence."

"The goodbye."

"They all shaped me."

"And honestly..."

He smiled.

"I'm grateful for all of it."

Aashika quietly listened.

There wasn't a trace of regret on his face.

Only gratitude.

She looked down at her melting ice cream.

"I think..."

"...I spent too many years wondering if life would've been different."

Mithran nodded.

"We all do."

"But yesterday..."

She smiled.

"...you answered that question for me."

"How?"

"You made me realise..."

"...different doesn't always mean better."

She looked at the city.

"We both reached where we were meant to."

Mithran smiled.

"I believe that too."

The wind became slightly stronger.

A few dry leaves drifted across the terrace before disappearing over the edge.

Aashika laughed softly.

"You know what I'll miss?"

"What?"

"The random phone calls."

"The birthday countdowns."

"The way you'd remember dates I forgot."

"The handmade gifts."

"The silly card games."

"The YouKnow cards."

"The terrible jokes."

She looked at him with a smile.

"And..."

"...having someone who listened to every single problem without ever making me feel judged."

Mithran smiled.

"I'll still listen."

She laughed.

"I know."

"You'll just be listening from another country."

He nodded.

"Distance has never been our biggest problem."

She smiled.

"No."

"It was always overthinking."

Both of them laughed together.

Just then...

the terrace door opened.

Lily stepped outside carrying her phone.

"There you both are."

"We've been searching everywhere."

"Were we?"

Aashika smiled.

"For the last fifteen minutes."

Lily crossed her arms dramatically.

"Aunty thought you both had gone to buy vegetables."

Mithran laughed.

"We've been here the whole time."

Lily walked over and stood beside them.

She looked out at the city.

"It's beautiful."

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"Bangalore?"

Mithran asked.

"No."

She smiled.

"This."

She pointed at both of them.

"A friendship that survived childhood..."

"...distance..."

"...misunderstandings..."

"...and time."

She looked at Aashika.

"You know..."

"I'm a little jealous."

Both of them looked at her.

"Not because of your past."

She smiled warmly.

"But because very few people get to keep a friend for this long."

Aashika reached out and hugged Lily.

"You have him now."

Lily smiled.

"I know."

"And I'm very lucky."

Mithran looked at both of them.

The two women who had shaped different chapters of his life.

One had unknowingly taught him what first love felt like.

The other had shown him that healing could also become love.

Looking at them standing together...
he realised something.

Life had never taken anything away from him.
It had simply changed the way happiness looked.
The three of them stood there for several more
minutes.
No one spoke.
No one needed to.
Sometimes...
the most beautiful memories are created in moments
so ordinary...
that you don't realise they're becoming memories until
years later.
Five years later...
Life never asked for permission before moving
forward.
It simply did.
One ordinary day at a time.
One sunrise after another.
One birthday after another.
Until suddenly...
five years had passed.
Mithran was thirty-five now.
The boy who once counted down to midnight
birthday wishes...
had become a man who smiled at ordinary mornings.
Australia no longer felt like a foreign country.
It had become home.
Not because he had forgotten India.
But because home had slowly grown in two places.
The apartment had changed over the years.
New furniture.
New photographs.
Books stacked neatly on wooden shelves.

Indoor plants that Lily insisted on buying every few months.

Most of them survived.

Some didn't.

They laughed about it every time.

Life wasn't extraordinary.

It was beautifully ordinary.

Weekdays belonged to work.

Weekends belonged to grocery shopping, movie nights, long walks, and video calls with family in India.

Sometimes they travelled.

Sometimes they stayed home doing absolutely nothing.

And strangely...

those became their favourite days.

Lily still laughed exactly the same way.

Mithran still forgot where he kept his keys.

She still reminded him to eat when work became busy.

He still reminded her to carry a jacket whenever winter arrived.

Marriage hadn't made life perfect.

It had simply given both of them someone to return home to.

One quiet Sunday afternoon...

rain tapped gently against the windows.

Lily decided to clean the storage room.

Something she had postponed for months.

"Mithran..."

she called from inside.

"Hmm?"

"Do we still need all these boxes?"

"Probably not."

he replied without looking up from his book.

"I'm throwing them."

"Okay."

A few minutes later...

her voice came again.

"What about this wooden box?"

Mithran froze.

For a brief moment...

he simply stared at the ceiling.

Then smiled.

"I wondered when you'd find it."

She carried it into the living room.

The box looked exactly the same.

Simple.

Old.

Worn at the corners.

Time had quietly touched it too.

She placed it on the table.

"So..."

she smiled.

"Is this the famous box?"

"The one you never let anyone open?"

Mithran closed his book.

Walked towards the table.

Ran his fingers gently across the lid.

"It is."

"Can I open it?"

He looked at her.

Smiled.

"You can."

She slowly lifted the lid.
Inside...
there wasn't any jewellery.
No expensive keepsakes.
No secrets wrapped in silk.
Only journals.
Carefully arranged.
Year after year.
Each one carrying a different chapter of a young
man's life.
Lily picked up the oldest one.
The cover had become slightly faded.
On the first page...
one date was written neatly.

August 5.

She looked at Mithran.
"May I?"
He nodded.
"You've waited five years."
"I think it's time."
She smiled.
Opened the first page.
And began reading.
Hours quietly disappeared.
The rain outside never stopped.
Neither did she.
She met an eighteen-year-old boy.
A boy who waited for birthdays as though they were
festivals.
A boy who travelled hundreds of kilometres just to
spend a few days with people he loved.

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A boy who made handmade gifts because he believed
effort mattered more than money.

A boy who remembered tiny details everyone else
forgot.

A boy who smiled easily.

But cried only when nobody could see.

Page after page...

she watched him grow.

She watched the excitement of childhood slowly
become the confusion of youth.

She watched misunderstandings.

Distance.

Growth.

Acceptance.

Healing.

Some pages made her laugh.

Some made her quietly wipe away tears.

One page still had a tiny water stain.

She realised...

it wasn't rain.

It was a tear.

From years ago.

She carefully closed that journal.

Picked up another.

Then another.

Then another.

By evening...

the rain had finally stopped.

The room had grown darker.

Only the warm light from the table lamp remained.

Lily closed the final journal.

She didn't speak immediately.

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Instead...
she looked at Mithran.
For a long moment.
Then she walked towards him.
Wrapped both arms around him.
And simply hugged him.
"I'm proud of you."
she whispered.
Mithran smiled.
"For what?"
"For surviving."
"For becoming this man."
"For never allowing pain to make you bitter."
He rested his forehead gently against hers.
"I wasn't alone."
"I know."
She smiled.
"You carried your past beautifully."
"And because of that..."
"...you gave me a beautiful present."
He laughed softly.
"You always know what to say."
"No."
She smiled.
"I learnt from your journals."
Both of them laughed.
A few moments later...
Mithran opened the last journal.
There was only one blank page left.
The final page.
He had left it empty for years.
Waiting.

Not for the right ending.
For the right feeling.
He uncapped his pen.
Thought for a moment.
Then slowly began writing.
"Some people become our future."
He smiled.
"Some become our forever memory."
He paused again.
His smile grew softer.
Calmer.
Then he wrote one final sentence.
**"Thank you, Aashika... for teaching me what love
feels like. Thank you, Lily... for teaching me that
love can smile again."**
He gently closed the journal.
Placed it inside the wooden box.
One by one...
the remaining journals followed.
He closed the lid.
Not to lock away his past.
But because...
it had finally become a completed story.
Not an unfinished one.
That evening...
his phone vibrated.
A family group notification.
A new photograph.
It was from India.
Aashika.
Her husband.
Their little daughter.

Standing beside Uncle and Auntie.
All of them smiling at the camera.
Mithran smiled.
Showed the picture to Lily.
"They look happy."
she said softly.
"They are."
he replied.
"And so are we."
He looked outside the window.
The rain clouds had disappeared.
Above them...
the evening sky had turned golden.
Life hadn't given him the story he imagined when he
was eighteen.
It had given him something far more beautiful.
A life filled with gratitude.
A friendship that never broke.
A love that never became selfish.
A family that never stopped caring.
And a woman beside him...
who loved every chapter that made him who he was.
He smiled.
Not because he had forgotten the past.
But because...
he no longer needed to hold on to it.
He simply whispered...
almost as though the wind itself would carry the
words across oceans.
"I hope you're still smiling, Aashika."
Somewhere...
thousands of kilometres away...

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Aashika tucked her daughter into bed.
Her husband switched off the lights.
Before closing the bedroom window...
she looked up at the night sky.
A small smile appeared on her face.
She didn't know why.
Sometimes...
peace arrives without explaining itself.
The same moon shone above both of them.
Not as two people who had lost each other.
But as two people who had once found themselves...
because of each other.

THE END

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CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
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Can Love Survive?

Yes.

Sometimes...

It survives because two people choose
patience over pride.

Sometimes...

It survives because one conversation
changes everything.

And sometimes...

It survives because...
someone waited.

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Some stories begin with "I love you."

Ours ended with "Thank you."

And somehow...

that became

the happier ending.

– MRETYUN JAI B

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Dear Reader,

If you've reached this page...
thank you.
For believing in these characters.
For waiting with them.
For hurting with them.
For smiling with them.
If Mithran taught you anything...
I hope it is this:
Never let overthinking speak louder than honesty.
Never let ego become stronger than love.
And never assume someone understands your silence.
Sometimes...
one conversation can save an entire lifetime.
Thank you...
for being part of this journey.

With gratitude,

MRETYUN JAI B

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Sometimes...

The happiest ending doesn't begin with a
grand confession.

It begins with one person choosing to
stay.

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CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
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Written by
MRETYUN JAI B

**"Some stories are written with
imagination.
This one was written with memories."**

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To everyone who finished both endings...

Thank you.

No matter which future you loved more...

I hope you never have to wonder,

"What if I had chosen differently?"

Choose with honesty.

Love with patience.

And when life gives you the chance...

don't wait too long to say what matters.

Because sometimes...

love survives.

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